HT BENGALURU

Friday, November 13, 2026

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Blackstone seen leading race for Actis co BluPine ▶P1

Huang exits Nvidia, India staff left with steep stock losses ▶P1

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HT BENGALURU VOL.1 NO.90

Friday, November 13, 2026

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Think Ahead. Think Growth.

mint primer

Metro operators are monetizing infra. Here's how

BY SAMIKSHA GOEL

Metro operators are looking beyond ticket sales to monetize infrastructure through station naming rights, advertising, and corporate tie-ups. InMobi's recent deal to secure naming rights to Bengaluru's Ibbaluru metro station is one example. *Mint* explains.

1 Why are metro rails looking beyond fares?

Metro projects need substantial capital, while passenger fares alone may not cover construction, operating and maintenance costs. Naming rights and corporate partnerships offer additional funding source, reducing reliance on government support, loans or fare hikes. Bengaluru Metro Rail Corp. Ltd (BMRCL) has developed a financing model in which companies contribute towards station construction or connectivity infrastructure in exchange for long-term branding and access rights. BMRCL is reportedly in talks with five companies to raise ₹460 crore through the programme.

2 What do advertisers get for investing?

Companies get the right to associate their brand with a metro station for a specified period, usually by adding the brand name as a prefix or suffix to the station's existing name. In Bengaluru, BMRCL has structured its corporate partnership model into three components: ₹65 crore for naming rights over 30 years, ₹25 crore for advertising and commercial space within the station, and ₹10 crore for direct access infrastructure such as a walkway connecting a station to a corporate campus, according to BMRCL's partnership framework. Rights and obligations vary across metro networks in different cities.

MINT

3 How much is the going rate in other cities?

In 2022, Mumbai Metro Rail Corp. (MMRC) awarded naming rights for five Metro 3 stations to Kotak Mahindra Bank, ICICI Lombard, and LIC for a total of ₹216 crore over five years, with a 5% annual escalation. Kochi Metro Rail Ltd set annual co-branding fees of ₹30–52 lakh across different stations, *The New Indian Express* reported in May 2025.

4 Which companies have already signed up?

In Bengaluru, Prestige Group secured a ₹80 crore deal for Bellandur station, with another ₹10 crore linked to a pedestrian skywalk. Earlier, Infosys Foundation and Embassy Group contributed ₹100 crore each for Konappana Agrahara and Kadubeesanahalli stations, respectively. Biocon contributed ₹65 crore for Hebbagodi station. In Mumbai, Atharva University acquired Valnai Meeth Chowky station naming rights. Arkade Developers secured Bangur Nagar station naming rights.

5 Why do companies want station branding?

Metro stations offer brands repeated exposure to daily commuters, building familiarity in key locations. This is valuable in areas where companies have offices, commercial projects or large customer bases. For firms along Bengaluru's Outer Ring Road, funding stations or walkways can improve access to their campuses, easing commutes for employees and visitors. Such partnerships also allow companies to frame their spending as public infrastructure investment rather than advertising spend.

QUICK EDIT

Police reforms

A recently published study by World Bank economist Sofia Amaral and her co-authors found that male police officers treated women complainants fairly after they had spent time in sensitization workshops.

The findings are based on a large-scale experiment in Bihar, where some senior officers (treatment group) took part in a sensitization workshop while others were left out (control group). The workshop attendees (treatment group) were less likely to dismiss complaints or blame victims of gender crimes, the study found. Female constables working with them were less likely to be anxious or harassed. Similar interventions can reshape attitudes of male officers, and improve gender outcomes, the study suggests.

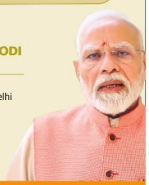
A more effective intervention might be to simply expand recruitment. Police personnel tend to face inordinately long hours. That makes women drop out early in their careers. At the top rungs, it looks like an all-boys club. If more officers were recruited, and work hours were regulated better, women might stay on the force for longer years. Male officers would get to hear women colleagues' concerns on a daily basis, without having to attend workshops.

QUOTE OF THE DAY

The dream of making our country developed has been with us since independence. But now this dream has a set date, 2047...

NARENDRA MODI
PRIME MINISTER

He was addressing journalists in New Delhi on Thursday.



INSIDE

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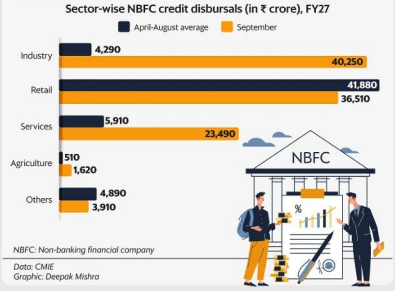
Business of Life | A new Bordeaux to be served chilled and enjoyed young >P16

mint | DATA BITES

WHICH SECTORS LED NBFC LENDING SURGE?

A sharp rise in industrial and services credit drove NBFCs' loan disbursals to ₹1.1 trillion in September, far exceeding the monthly average of ₹57,480 crore from April to August this year.

Sector-wise NBFC credit disbursals (in ₹ crore), FY27



NBFC: Non-banking financial company

Data: CMIE
Graphic: Deepak Mishra

COLUMNS

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THE FIVE STAGES OF AI GRIEF AND WHERE WE ARE CURRENTLY PLACED >P15

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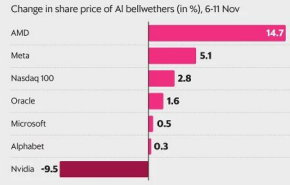
PLAIN FACTS

DATA RECAP THE WEEK IN CHARTS

CURATED BY HOWINDIALIVES.COM | feedback@livemint.com

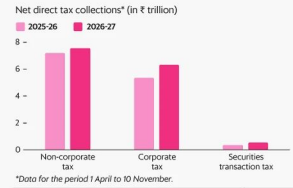
From governance concerns surrounding artificial intelligence (AI) bellwether Nvidia to depleting reservoirs threatening India's agricultural output, corporate taxes outpacing non-corporate collections, a rise in mutual fund SIP stoppages and the BCCI exploring an expansion of the Indian Premier League (IPL), here are the key developments of the week in numbers.

NVIDIA'S TURMOIL



JENSEN HUANG resigned on Thursday as chief executive of Nvidia after reports of extramarital affairs with an alleged Chinese spy. Nvidia has been embroiled in controversy ever since Huang admitted to his extramarital relationship with Alice Huang, a former senior executive at Singapore chip firm Megaspeed, reportedly identified by US intelligence agencies as a Chinese intelligence asset. This prompted an independent probe by Nvidia's board, while Huang denied any knowledge of espionage. Amid the controversy, Nvidia shares slumped 10%, wiping billions off its market value. It has also drawn Nvidia into escalating US-China tensions.

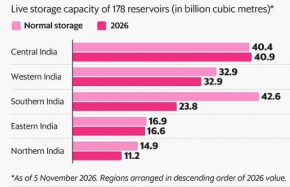
TAX MOP UP



NET DIRECT tax collections rose 11.8% year-on-year to ₹14.42 trillion as of 10 November, according to provisional data released by the Income Tax Department.

Taxes paid by non-corporates, led by individuals, continued to account for the largest share of collections. However, corporate tax and securities transaction tax (STT) collections grew faster, rising 18% and 51.6%, respectively. The jump in STT collections comes amid a wider debate over capital market taxation in India, with the government reportedly considering changes to long-term capital gains tax and STT ahead of the Union Budget in February 2027.

IRRIGATION SECURITY



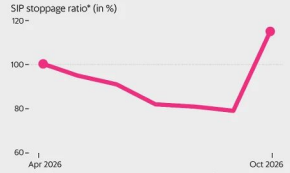
FOLLOWING A deficient monsoon, water levels in India's 178 reservoirs were 21% lower than a year earlier as of 5 November and about 17% below normal, *Mint* reported. Reservoirs in southern India recorded the largest shortfall against normal storage levels, at 44%, followed by northern India at 24%. Low water levels have raised concerns over irrigation, agricultural output, food prices and hydropower generation.

The impact is already visible in the pace of rabi sowing. As of 6 November, wheat acreage was 12% lower year-on-year, while pulses and oilseeds were down 14% and 24%, respectively. Rice was the only major crop to record an increase, with acreage up 3%.

NUMBERS TALK

- **₹2-4 per litre:** The milk price hike announced by Amul and Mother Dairy, citing higher procurement and fuel costs. Average retail prices have risen from ₹55 in November 2022 to ₹61 in October 2026.
- **₹62,370 crore:** Fertilizer subsidy approved by the Centre for this rabi season, up 64% year-on-year. The higher allocation aims to keep farmers' input costs affordable amid volatile global prices.
- **₹5,000 crore:** Blackstone's investment in IIFL Finance for a 16% stake. Non-bank financiers Manappuram Finance, Shriram Finance and Sammaan Capital also attracted foreign investment in 2026.
- **$7.1 billion:** Net loss reported by Japan's SoftBank Group in the second quarter, its first quarterly loss in nearly two years. This followed a $3.7 billion write-down on US data centre investments.
- **7:** The average number of working days of paternity leave taken by Indian fathers, the lowest among the 12 major economies surveyed by global hiring platform Deel. The US average was 28 days.

SIP STOPPAGES



SYSTEMATIC INVESTMENT plans (SIPs) discontinued in mutual funds exceeded new registrations in October, pushing the SIP stoppage ratio to 116%, the highest since April 2025, according to Association of Mutual Funds in India (Amfi) data. This was the second time in fiscal year 2026-27 (FY27) that the ratio crossed 100%, the first being in April, signalling more discontinuations than new registrations. Yet, monthly SIP contributions stayed close to their record levels in August and September. Equity mutual funds, however, saw October net inflows fall 14% sequentially. While large-cap funds saw higher inflows, mid-cap and small-cap funds saw declines.

IPL EXPANSION

Growth in valuation of teams in the Indian Premier League (IPL)

	Valuation at inception (in ₹ crore)	Compounded annual growth* (in %)
Mumbai Indians	448	23
Royal Challengers Bengaluru	446	22
Chennai Super Kings	364	24
Delhi Capitals	336	24
Punjab Kings	304	23
Kolkata Knight Riders	300	26
Rajasthan Royals	268	25
BSE Sensex		9

*Between 2008 and 2026. Sensex value for 2008 is as of 24 January, when the eight IPL teams were auctioned. 2026 team valuations use the lower end of the estimated valuation band. Teams are ranked by their valuation at inception.

Source: Fanatic Sports Hurun India's Most Valuable Sports Teams 2026; Howindialives.com calculation
mint

THE BOARD of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) is exploring adding at least two teams to the 10-franchise IPL from the 2028 season, coinciding with a new media rights cycle, *Mint* reported. Pune and Vadodara have emerged as leading contenders, but discussions are at an early stage. Each new franchise could command a valuation of over $1 billion. IPL last expanded ahead of the 2022 season, adding Lucknow Super Giants and Gujarat Titans for $940 million and $750 million, respectively. IPL franchise valuations have risen at a compounded annual rate of 22-26% since the league's inception.

www.howindialives.com is a database and search engine for public data

MINT BEST OF THE WEEK

IPL eyes expansion

The BCCI is exploring plans to expand the Indian Premier League (IPL) to at least 12 teams from 2028, with Pune and Vadodara emerging as potential destinations for new franchises. Each team could be valued at over $1 billion The proposal remains at an early stage.

JSW exits airport auction

JSW Group has decided not to bid for 11 airports in the Centre's latest privatisation round, calling the smaller assets commercially unviable and a "quasi-real estate play". However, the group may reconsider if larger airports such as Kolkata and Chennai are opened up for private participation.

₹5 internet sachet clicks

As mobile recharges become costlier, low-income households are turning to ₹5-10 public Wi-Fi sachets for affordable internet access, with startups such as Wiom building neighbourhood hotspot networks. But India's PM-WANI scheme remains far short of its targets.

HT BENGALURU VOL.1 NO.90 Rs.15.00 20 PAGES

Friday, November 13, 2026

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Sunil Mittal interview: Airtel to be debt-free by 2029 ▶P12

Jewellers' gain masks gold volume dip ▶P4

SENSEX **81,911** ↑ **31.6** NIFTY **25,299.35** ↑ **44.3** DOLLAR **₹94.12** ↑ **₹0.40** EURO **₹104.33** ↑ **₹0.02** OIL **$92.21** ↓ **$0.66** POUND **₹124.82** ↑ **₹0.03**

Stock shock for Nvidia's Indian staff as CEO exits

Indian employees' RSUs down $570 million as AI scare, spy scandal hit stock

Shouvik Das & Varun Sood
NEW DELHI/BENGALURU

Even as scandal-hit Jensen Huang resigned as chief executive of Nvidia Corp. in the middle of an espionage probe and an office affair, employees of the company's Indian unit are staring at paper losses of as much as $570 million.

Just a month ago, employees at Nvidia Graphics Pvt. Ltd, the chip maker's Indian branch, were sitting on a stock windfall; however, a market panic around artificial intelligence (AI) companies and a scandal around Huang have erased much of it.

Employees held about 7.05 million unvested restricted stock units (RSUs) as on 31 March 2026, a *Mint* review of the company's financial statement filed with corporate affairs ministry showed. At the time, shares of the world's most valuable company traded at around $170, making these RSUs worth about $1.2 billion. Between then and 6 October, the shares rose to $244, boosting the RSUs' value to $1.73 billion.

Since then, the on-paper gains have plunged, first because of worries over a slowdown in AI progress and, over the past week, because of reports of Chinese spying. On Thursday, the chipmaker named chief financial officer Colette Kress as interim CEO. In a statement, Kress said that Nvidia's "strength has always come from its people" and that she was "committed to building on the extraordinary foundation Jensen created over the last 33 years."

As of 10:30 pm India time, Nvidia shares were trading at $165.08 per share, down 5% from the previous day. This values the unvested RSUs for Indian employees at about $1.16 billion— down roughly $570 million in paper gains in six weeks.

Nvidia did not respond to a detailed questionnaire.

To be sure, the figure for Nvidia RSUs received by employees could have changed since March. Nvidia RSUs usually get credited to employee accounts over four years: 25% after the first year and

TURN TO PAGE 6

GRAPHIC BLUES

AP

INDIA HIT

BIGGEST impact may be on long-serving staff at Nvidia India

NVIDIA India had 5,590 employees at the end of Mar 2026

HIT based on when shares were given, whether staff held on

Huang out; move to roil AI economy

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

Nvidia Corp. CEO Jensen Huang was ousted from his post after reports of two affairs, including one with a woman suspected of spying for China. Longtime CFO Colette Kress is taking the job of interim CEO, Nvidia said. The exit deepens a crisis partly of Nvidia's own making, since the company has long lacked a clear succession plan. P10

Blackstone seen leading race for Actis co BluPine

Sneha Shah & Priyamvada C.
MUMBAI

Global private equity firm Blackstone is emerging as the frontrunner to acquire renewable energy platform BluPine Energy from UK-based Actis in a deal that could value the company at $1.7-1.8 billion, three people with direct knowledge of the matter said.

"Blackstone seems to be leading the talks and may soon enter exclusivity," said one of the people cited above. Blackstone is competing closely with Brookfield and INOX Clean Energy, to acquire BluPine, the people said.

Mint was the first to report private equity and strategic investor interest in the deal, including that of Blackstone, on 18 August. Blackstone and Actis spokespersons declined to comment. Emails sent to INOX did not elicit a response till the time of publishing. Brookfield declined to comment.

The scale of India's renewable energy opportunity has attracted both domestic and global investors. Investments in the sector have gathered pace in recent years, with the government targeting 500GW of installed non-fossil-fuel capacity by 2030. Achieving this target will require an estimated investment of about ₹42 trillion, according to government estimates.

The deal could value BluPine at $1.7-1.8 billion. REUTERS

Actis launched BluPine Energy in 2022, targeting 4GW of utility-scale solar, wind and energy storage capacity through a buy-and-build strategy. The company develops projects with both government and commercial and industrial (C&I) power purchase agreements (PPAs) across India. In the same year, BluPine acquired an operating solar portfolio of 404MW

TURN TO PAGE 6

DON'T MISS

REUTERS

Rupee rebound lifts dollar returns on stocks

A surge in foreign inflows has helped the rupee recover, boosting returns on Indian equities in dollar terms relative to those in rupee terms and reversing a prolonged period of underperformance for overseas investors. >P4

Audit, advisory firms roll out 10-15% pay hikes, bonuses

Retention is the keyword for advisory and audit firms this year. They rolled out neat 10-15% increments this year, apart from bonuses, special monetary rewards and promotions. Top performers in some cases received hikes of 25-28%. >P7

Bodhi Tree picks up a majority stake in A2B for $180 million

Investment platform Bodhi Tree Systems on Thursday acquired a majority stake in the restaurant and snack shop chain Adyar Ananda Bhavan (A2B) for $180 million, providing fuel for its domestic and overseas expansion. >P8

Retail inflation rises to two-year high of 6.09% in October

Retail inflation rose to a two-year high of 6.09% in October, primarily due to elevated food prices and an unfavourable base effect. Inflation has breached the Reserve Bank of India's upper tolerance limit of 6% for the first time since the new series was rolled out. >P2

Discoms pay up to 4x cap in supply crunch

Rituraj Baruah
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NEW DELHI

India's state-run electricity distributors are paying up to four times the regulated exchange ceiling to lock in short-term power supplies, as a severe supply crunch pushes utilities towards bilateral deals.

Driven by soaring temperatures, a patchy monsoon and tight coal inventories, electricity prices in the uncapped bilateral market touched ₹30 per unit this summer, according to the government portal and three people familiar with the matter. Prices for supplies contracted for the coming months have since gone as high as ₹41.50 per unit.

Spot rates on power exchanges are capped at ₹10 per unit, and at ₹20 in the specialised high-price day-ahead market (HP-DAM).

Increased procurement at higher rates could raise the average cost of supply for discoms by 2-3%, depending on their reliance on short-term and market-based power procurement.

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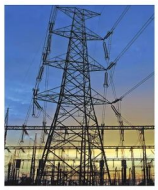

In Sep, power shortages went past 30 mn units per day. MINT

SpiceJet falters on three fronts

Dipali Banka & Abhishek Law
MUMBAI/NEW DELHI

SpiceJet Ltd is struggling to keep its planes flying, pay its suppliers, and clear employee salaries, with its cash crunch spilling into day-to-day operations.

The strain is most evident in its supplier payments. Between April and September, the airline missed the 45-day legal payment deadline on more than 85% of invoices from small suppliers, leaving ₹63.03 crore unpaid, according to its latest regulatory filing.

Flight operations have also taken a hit. In September, nearly two in five SpiceJet flights were delayed by more than two hours, while one in five was cancelled, according to data from the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA).

Employees, too, have been caught in the squeeze. Salary payments have been delayed, with some dues reportedly outstanding for more than four months, according to two company employees.

The mounting cash crunch is reflected in the airline's

TURN TO PAGE 6

SpiceJet's flight operations have taken a hit. REUTERS

Consumer AI startups win VC backing

Salman S. H
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MUMBAI

Venture capital investors are doubling down on Indian consumer artificial intelligence (AI) startups, betting that tailored applications for everyday tasks—from spoken English to personal finance—will persuade users to pay for AI.

The immediate challenge for these startups is no longer acquiring users, but retaining them in a price-sensitive market. Investment activity is accelerating across stages. Trading platform Sahi is seeking $40 million to $50 million at a valuation of $400 million to $500 million, while spoken-English app Supernova is in talks to raise $15 million to $20 million from Vertex Ventures Southeast Asia & India and Verlinvest, *Mint* reported earlier.

Several others have closed rounds this year. Credit and personal finance app Oolka raised $14 million in a round led by Accel, with participation from Lightspeed and Z47. Wellness platform SuperLiving secured $7 million led by Lightspeed, alongside Kae Capital and All In Capital. Professional networking startup Profound.me raised $1.5 million from investors including Stellaris Venture Partners and 3one4 Capital.

The premise of consumer AI is convenience: building applications tailored to specific needs so users do not have to master complex prompts on general-purpose chatbots such as ChatGPT. For investors, however, the test is not simply whether users try these services, but whether they find enough value to keep using them and pay for them.

That makes sustained engagement and repeat usage important measures of a product's potential. Sunitha Viswanathan, partner at Kae Capital, said the fund assesses its consumer AI investments by tracking continued engagement, time spent and revenue from repeat users. "The customer must care about the product, want to use it and continue paying to return," she said.

Delivering a tangible outcome is central to that equation. "When a product actually delivers an outcome, that's when Indian consumers are willing to pay," said Harsha Kumar, partner at Lightspeed. The fund focuses on tools that help users save money, earn money or solve specific fric-

TURN TO PAGE 11

The immediate challenge for these startups is no longer acquiring users, but retaining them in a price-sensitive market. BLOOMBERG

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Digital Banking
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Blocking
ATM Card | YINB Blocking | UPI Blocking | AEPS Deregistration

Service Requests
YINB/YONO Business/ YONO Blocking | WhatsApp Registration | Account Statement
HL Statement | Cheque Book Issuance/ Dispatch Status/Stop | HL/EL/TDS Certificate
Loan Registration | AEPS Deregistration/ UPI Blocking

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Of the 39,033 complaints on MSE ODR portal, only 4,030 stand resolved. ISTOCKPHOTO

Redressal tool fails to shrink MSE payment dispute pile

Manas Pimpalkhare
manas.pimpalkhare@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

A government-backed online dispute resolution platform for India's small businesses has disposed of just 10.3% of the complaints it has received since it was launched in June 2025, highlighting the challenges of resolving delayed-payment disputes through digital mechanisms.

Of the 39,033 complaints filed on the MSE Online Dispute Resolution (ODR) portal until 10 November, only 4,030 had been disposed of through a combination of artificial intelligence-assisted settlements, conciliation, arbitration and proceedings before micro and small enterprises facilitation councils, data on the portal showed.

The slow resolution rate assumes significance given the scale of delayed payments in India's small-business ecosystem. The FY26 Economic Survey estimated that approximately ₹8.1 trillion was locked in delayed payments to businesses.

The MSE ODR scheme is part of the World Bank-backed Raising and Accelerating MSME Performance (RAMP) programme, which has a five-year budget of ₹6,062 crore starting FY23.

The scheme allows MSEs to file an online complaint against buyers and try AI-assisted negotiations before reaching micro and small enterprises facilitation councils (MSEFCs). These councils resolve delayed-payment disputes through conciliation and, if that fails, arbitration.

The MSE ODR scheme allows India's 97 million micro and small enterprises to file delayed-payment complaints online, seek AI-assisted amicable settlements, and pursue conciliation and arbitration through MSEFCs to recover dues.

Industry experts said these councils require capacity building, while smaller businesses face challenges related to awareness.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

RIL, Waaree among bidders on shortlist for storage PLI

The Centre has shortlisted 22 bidders for the 10GWh battery energy storage system tender

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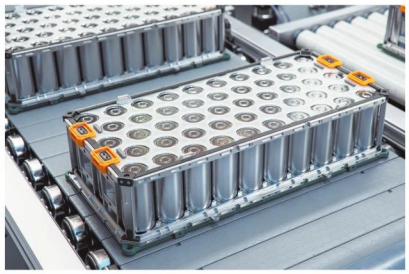

PLI-ACC scheme aims to create 50GWh of domestic cell-making capacity. ISTOCKPHOTO

Reliance Industries Ltd (RIL), Waaree Energy Storage Solutions Pvt. Ltd, Megha Engineering and Infrastructures Ltd, JSW Neo Energy Ltd, Exide Energy Solutions Ltd, ACME Solar Holdings Ltd and Amara Raja Advanced Cell Technologies Pvt. Ltd are among 22 bidders shortlisted for the Centre's 10GWh battery energy storage system (BESS) tender under the ₹18,100 crore production-linked incentive scheme for advanced chemistry cells (PLI-ACC).

The PLI-ACC scheme aims to create 50GWh of domestic cell-making capacity. The latest 10GWh tender follows the allocation of incentives for the remaining 40GWh to Ola Electric (20GWh), Reliance Industries and its subsidiary Reliance New Energy Ltd (15GWh), and Rajesh Exports Ltd (5GWh), which has faced controversy.

In June, the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) alleged that Rajesh Exports and its promoters were responsible for financial misrepresentation to the tune of ₹15 trillion.

This 10GWh capacity, for which the government has shortlisted 22 bidders, was earmarked for grid-scale storage in light of the country's growing power requirements and renewable energy deployment, whereas earlier incentive allocations were end-use-agnostic, the ministry of heavy industries said on Thursday.

₹3,620 cr Govt incentives to release under the BESS tender

The tender is significant as ₹3,620 crore in government incentives will be available to selected bidders once they make the required investments in cell manufacturing and start selling India-made advanced chemistry cells, according to the scheme guidelines and tender documents.

The remaining shortlisted companies are: Avaada Electro Ltd, Fujiyama Power Systems Ltd, GK Energy Ltd, Godawari New Energy Pvt. Ltd, JPM Energy Solutions Pvt. Ltd, Lineage Power Pvt. Ltd, Mahendra Sponge and Power Ltd, Nsure Reliable Power Solutions Pvt. Ltd, Renew Photovoltaics Pvt. Ltd, Sai Bioenergy Pvt. Ltd, Shirdi Sai Electricals Ltd, Sun Drops Energia Ltd, Utex New Energy Pvt. Ltd, Vikram Solar Ltd, Zetsol Energy Pvt. Ltd.

Mint's queries emailed to Reliance, Waree, Amara Raja and Exide late on Thursday evening did not receive an immediate response.

Launched in 2021, the PLI ACC scheme has failed to gain traction, with disbursements under the flagship battery-manufacturing incentive scheme remaining at zero. The government has previously cited a lack of available technology and skilled manpower, delays in importing critical machinery, and the unavailability of upstream components as key reasons developers have been unable to meet their targets.

As of February 2026, Ola Electric had developed 1GWh of cell-manufacturing capacity, while the other beneficiaries had developed none.

Mint reported in August that the government had given Ola Electric and Reliance New Energy an extension to complete their respective projects by 2031, while the third beneficiary, Rajesh Exports, was not given one in light of the Sebi investigation. The extension applied only to companies that won contracts in the first round in 2022. Reliance secured another 10GWh in a subsequent round in September 2024, with a gestation period until July 2027 and incentives running until 2032. That allocation has not received any extension.

₹18,100 cr Funds earmarked for the PLI-ACC scheme

The tender for grid-scale energy storage is significant as it is critical for storing surplus electricity and supplying it when demand rises. India routinely curtails solar generation during peak daylight hours because of inadequate storage, forcing renewable power to be backed down when the grid can't absorb the excess.

CAG to audit power discoms amid rise in financial stress

Dhirendra Kumar
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NEW DELHI

The audit will initially focus on the operational and financial performance. MINT

The national auditor, the Comptroller and Auditor General of India (CAG), has launched a nationwide performance audit of power distribution companies (discoms), which face mounting financial stress, high debt and persistent operational inefficiencies, as part of a four-year exercise to assess the health of India's power sector, according to two government officials.

The audit will initially focus on operational and financial performance, with particular attention to power procurement, demand forecasting, metering, regulatory accounting and consumer services.

The broader exercise will cover all major segments of the power sector, including generation, transmission, distribution and renewable energy, over the next four years, said the first among the two officials cited above.

The move comes against the backdrop of significant financial weaknesses in the distribution sector. As of 31 March 2025, 24 discoms had negative net worth, with accumulated losses of ₹3.42 trillion. Their outstanding borrowings amounted to ₹7.26 trillion, attracting an annual interest burden of ₹77,653 crore, the official said.

Of the discoms covered in the data, 41 reported aggregate profits of ₹32,661 crore in FY25, while 23 incurred combined losses of ₹29,959 crore.

"The audit will examine whether government support to the distribution sector is translating into structural improvements or increasingly being used to meet the cost of accumulated losses and debt," said the second official. Both the officials spoke on the condition of anonymity.

Revenue grants to discoms increased 69.4% to ₹94,095 crore between FY21 and FY25, compared with a 16% rise in capital grants to ₹1.25 trillion during the same period.

"Government support is increasingly meeting the cost of losses, debt and interest rather than investment," this official said. *Mint*'s queries emailed to the CAG spokesperson remained unanswered.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

India a haven for global investors with trade pacts in place: Goyal

Rajeev Jayaswal
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NEW DELHI

Union commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal. PTI

India is a safe harbour for global investors, promising preferential access to three-fourths of the $115 trillion world economy as New Delhi already finalised free trade deals with countries representing a combined GDP of $70 trillion and plans to add another $15 trillion soon, commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal said on Thursday.

He was addressing around 3,000 national and international delegates from 60 countries at the inaugural session of the 31st Partnership Summit in Visakhapatnam.

The two-day summit is being organized by the Confederation of Indian Industry (CII) in association with the ministry of commerce and industry, with the Andhra Pradesh government as the host.

"In this turbulent global world, India offers an oasis in the desert," Goyal said, referring to geopolitical conflicts and trade disputes that have disrupted global supply chains.

Hindustan Times

Goyal drew a parallel between India's trade policy and the Motupalli pillar inscription, or the *abhaya-sasana* (charter of protection), issued by Kakatiya king Ganapatideva about 800 years ago.

"It made a simple promise: duties would be fair and if a storm wrecked your ship on our coast, your cargo would be protected," he said, adding that "India renews that charter for every investor".

"Whatever storm rages around the world, whatever may be the wars and conflicts that trouble the rest of the world, our policies will remain predictable, our laws will be fair and your investment will be safe," he said.

Goyal said India offered investors three assurances—open markets, the capability to deliver and reliability or trust.

On open markets, he said India had finalized nine free trade or preferential trade agreements in the past four-and-a-half years with 38 developed countries.

"In the last four-and-a-half years, we have finalised nine free trade agreements or preferential trade agreements covering 38 developed countries. And friends, these 38 countries together represent $60 trillion of global GDP," he said. According to government officials, India is in an advanced stage of finalising a free trade agreement with Canada.

Retail inflation at two-year high in Oct

Dhirendra Kumar
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NEW DELHI

India's retail inflation rose to a two-year high of 6.09% in October from 5.54% in September, primarily due to elevated food prices and an unfavourable base effect. Inflation has breached the Reserve Bank of India's upper tolerance limit of 6% for the first time since the new series was rolled out in January 2026.

A *Mint* poll of 15 economists had estimated the consumer price index (CPI)-based inflation to rise to 6% in October.

Food inflation, a key component of the CPI, rose to 8.94% in October from 7.74% in September, 5.97% in June, according to provisional data released by the ministry of statistics and programme implementation on Thursday.

"The primary reason for inflation breaching 6% is food inflation. This is seen in the higher rural inflation that stood at 6.6% while urban inflation still printed within the tolerance band at 5.4%. The higher weight of food in the consumption basket of rural households has led to this higher inflation number," said Ranen Banerjee, partner and leader, economic advisory, PwC India. He added that with inflation breaching the tolerance band, the monetary policy committee (MPC) is likely to further tighten policy with a 25-50 basis points (bps) rate hike at its next meeting.

Shaky base
Food inflation rose to 8.94% in October, and, dovetailed with an unfavourable base effect, lifted retail inflation to 6.09%.

Year-on-year retail inflation (in %), base year 2024

Source: Statistics ministry

mint

GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

A *Mint* poll of 15 economists had estimated the consumer price index-based inflation to rise to 6% in October

Persistently high inflation, compounded by elevated crude oil prices and risks to economic growth from the West Asia war, could further complicate the central bank's policy decisions.

RBI raised interest rates by 25 basis points in the first week of October and shifted its monetary policy stance to calibrated tightening.

"India's headline inflation tested the upper end of the RBI's tolerance band in October to a two-year high, with a sharp food-driven upmove accompanied by signs of broadening out of price pressures on a sequential basis," said Radhika Rao, senior economist and executive director at DBS Bank. "With headline inflation yet to peak, compounded by an unfavourable base effect, the central bank's quarterly projection is likely to be revised higher. The data reinforces our expectation of a second successive rate hike in December."

Higher inflation threatens to dampen consumer demand and weigh on economic growth. RBI governor Sanjay Malhotra said in October that inflation and its outlook were not benign, adding that headline inflation was expected to average nearly 5.8% over the next three quarters.

In October, the RBI's MPC raised its retail inflation projection for FY27 to 5.2%, from 5% in August, citing persistent supply-side pressures arising from deficient southwest monsoon rainfall, El Niño conditions and volatility in international oil prices. The RBI expects inflation to peak at 6% in the December quarter of FY27, then moderate to 5.7% in the March quarter.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

MINT SHORTS

Modi to attend Asean summit in Manila on 16-17 November

New Delhi: Prime Minister Narendra Modi will visit the Philippines from 16 to 17 November to attend the summit of the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (Asean) in Manila, the foreign ministry said on Thursday. India is a strategic partner of the 11-member grouping, which also includes Indonesia, Malaysia, Myanmar, Cambodia, and Timor-Leste. PTI

REUTERS

India, Canada trade pact talks may conclude by Dec: minister

Visakhapatnam: Canadian minister of international trade Maninder Sidhu on Thursday said negotiations are on between India and Canada for a trade pact and expressed hope that these talks will conclude by the time Prime Minister Narendra Modi visits Canada next month. India and Canada are currently holding the sixth round negotiations for the Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA). PTI

Council of ministers likely to meet on 18 November

New Delhi: Prime Minister Narendra Modi is likely to meet his entire council of ministers after his return from the Asean summit, on 18 November, during which he is expected to discuss a host of issues including governance, reforms and outreach to women and youth on welfare and development schemes. The meeting is part of the ongoing exercise aimed at helping ministers better understand the issues faced by the government. PTI

Gulf overtakes Russia in India's crude imports

BLOOMBERG

India's oil imports from the Persian Gulf have overtaken those from Russia for the first time since the Iran war began, as shuttle runs by tankers help restore flows through the Strait of Hormuz. Crude shipments reaching India via Hormuz have climbed to 2.1 million barrels a day so far this month, surpassing Russian imports of 1.8 million barrels a day, according to Kpler. BLOOMBERG

PLI: Niti Aayog says 70% of targeted segments on track

New Delhi: A sector-wise assessment of PLI scheme shows that nearly 70% of the targeted segments are on track, with particularly strong outcomes emerging in electronics, telecom and pharmaceuticals drugs, Niti Aayog said in a report on Thursday. The report also said the pace of outcomes varies across sectors. PTI

REUTERS

BEML to build tunnelling machines to cut China reliance

BEML Ltd aims to develop tunnel-boring machines, initially focusing on smaller machines, before expanding into larger equipment, chairman and managing director Shantanu Roy said in an interview. The move is part of India's broader efforts to reduce import reliance, particularly from China. BLOOMBERG

CORRECTIONS AND CLARIFICATIONS

A 12 November, Page 1 story, 'New state law to shield investors in Andhra Pradesh', should have identified the placeline as Vijayawada. The error is regretted.

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BSE Sensex		Nifty 50		Nifty 500		Nifty Next 50		Nifty 100		BSE 150 MidCap		BSE 250 SmallCap	
CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE
81,911.01	0.04	25,299.35	0.18	23,865.80	0.36	73,481.25	-0.01	26,254.15	0.14	16,780.38	0.67	7,052.78	1.00
PREVIOUS CLOSE	OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE	OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE	OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE	OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE	OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE	OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE	OPEN
81,879.40	81,762.27	25,255.05	25,213.50	23,779.30	23,775.60	73,486.20	73,552.05	26,216.80	26,185.70	16,669.29	16,723.60	6,982.71	7,003.99
HIGH	LOW	HIGH	LOW	HIGH	LOW	HIGH	LOW	HIGH	LOW	HIGH	LOW	HIGH	LOW
82,325.61	81,567.15	25,384.80	25,142.95	23,940.80	23,712.60	73,948.80	73,238.55	26,356.20	26,111.25	16,847.80	16,650.50	7,065.86	6,995.33

Solar EPC drags Tata Power Q2

Manish Joshi
feedback@livemint.com

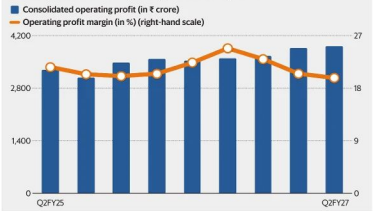
Tata Power's operating profit for Q2FY27 rose 11% year-on-year (y-o-y) to ₹3,917 crore. But comparing this with the 26% revenue growth can be misleading, given the firm's diverse business mix. Its regulated power business, for instance, operates on a fixed return on equity (RoE) of 15.5%.

Profit from regulated operations moves in line with growth in regulated equity, making revenue growth and operating margins less relevant metrics. Investors should focus instead on Tata Power's non-regulated businesses: renewable power generation, solar EPC, and solar equipment manufacturing. These offer more meaningful comparisons with peers such as NTPC Green and Waaree Energies.

Renewable power generation was a bright spot, with operating profit rising 32% y-o-y to ₹1,061 crore, largely driven by a 25% rise in capacity to 7.1GW. However, 11% load curtailment and transmission constraints remained dampeners. Battery energy storage solutions (BESS) could help address curtailment.

Energizing factor

Tata Power's operating profit growth of 11% year-on-year in Q2FY27 was aided by the renewable power generation segment.



Source: Company presentations

MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

Solar EPC, on the other hand, was a drag. Operating profit halved to ₹180 crore in Q2, tempering the renewable generation business's strong performance. While rooftop solar projects, largely for residential use, did well, a sharp decline in large project orders hurt revenue and pulled down operating margin by 410 basis points y-o-y to 10%.

The solar equipment business, housed under TP Solar, has 4.3GW of cell and module manufacturing capacity. Operating profit rose 10% y-o-y to ₹512 crore. Although module sales declined 19%, higher realizations and a better sales mix helped offset the weakness.

The Mundra power plant and the legal battle with Kleros Capital Partners remain two overhangs. Under the supplementary power purchase agreement (SPPA), Tata Power has until 31 December to continue Mundra operations.

Kleros won its case in the Singapore International Commercial Court in August. Tata Power has not made any provision for a potential liability, having approached the Singapore Court of Appeal.

The company maintains that its capacity expansion and ₹25,000 crore capital expenditure plans for FY27 are on track. Renewable generation capacity is expected to reach 12.2GW by FY28. Rival NTPC Green has 11GW of solar and wind capacity.

If Tata Power delivers on this expansion target, its valuations could offer some upside. NTPC Green trades at an enterprise value (EV) of ₹7 crore per MW of capacity. Applying the same benchmark to Tata Power's targeted renewable generation capacity would imply a ₹84,000 crore valuation for the business alone, equivalent to 70% of Tata Power's ₹1.16 trillion market capitalization.

GREEN PUSH

RENEWABLE power generation profit rose 32% year-on-year to ₹1,061 crore

GREEN capacity is expected to reach 12.2GW by FY28, and that could offer upside in valuation

Similarly, Waaree Energies, a solar EPC player and equipment manufacturer, trades at an EV/Ebitda multiple of 9x, based on *Bloomberg* consensus estimates for FY28. Applying this multiple to Tata Power's solar EPC and equipment businesses would imply a combined valuation of ₹27,000 crore, based on annualized HIFY27 financials.

Leverage is the key caveat. Tata Power's net debt is expected to reach about ₹80,000 crore by FY28-end, far above NTPC Green and Waaree, though regulated businesses give it earnings pure-play peers lack.

Thermax's H2 recovery bet runs into old execution hurdles

Harsha Jethmalani
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Thermax's share price has nearly halved from its 52-week high of ₹5,277.80 seen in June, weighed down by continued earnings disappointment.

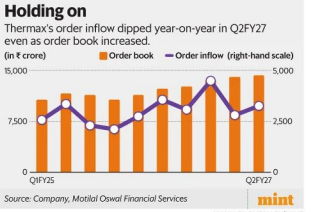
In Q2FY27, deferred higher-margin international shipments, worth ₹200–300 crore, capped consolidated revenue growth at 11% year-on-year (y-o-y) to ₹2,756 crore. Management expects H2FY27 revenue to touch ₹7,000 crore versus ₹5,059 crore in H1. Revenue growth will be buoyed by export orders and lower contribution from low-margin legacy projects nearing completion.

Order inflows fell 8% y-o-y to ₹3,259 crore, due to weak intake in the industrial products segment. HIFY27 order inflows slid 4% to ₹6,100 crore, taking the order book as of September to ₹14,250 crore, up 16%. From its earlier guidance of over 10% growth in FY27 order inflows, Thermax now anticipates high single-digit growth. It expects at least one supercritical boiler order in H2.

However, JM Financial Institutional Securities noted that even if one large thermal power win is factored in, FY27 order inflow growth is likely to be only 5%. "Investors are occasionally enthused about the potential for order wins in the thermal power space, which seems fair. However, given the chronic execution issues Thermax continues to face, especially in PSU projects in India, we will be wary of such wins unless management addresses fundamental project engineering and execution issues," it said.

Holding on

Thermax's order inflow dipped year-on-year in Q2FY27 even as order book increased.



Source: Company, Motilal Oswal Financial Services

MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

Moreover, the fixed-price nature of Thermax's order book means margin dilution if commodity inflation persists. Q2FY27 Ebitda margin at 7% was flat y-o-y delayed international shipments and project impairment in green solutions segment.

The management expects margin recovery from Q3 and is confident of sustaining a high single-digit margin.

Although Thermax has new growth drivers such as data centre solutions, utility power projects, and the ramp-up of its chemical business, re-rating is a distant dream unless execution improves, coupled with better margins.

Motilal Oswal Financial Services has cut FY27/FY28/FY29 estimates by 20%/17%/10%. It has also reduced its two-year forward price-to-earnings multiple from 40 to 30 to account for continued earnings cuts, driven by losses in one segment after another, sub-par return ratios, and a fixed-price order book.

Mark to Market writers do not hold positions in the companies discussed here unless otherwise informed

Zee announces ₹600 cr buyback at 24% premium

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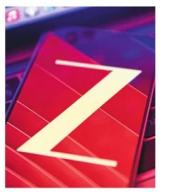


The buyback price is 23.8% above the company's Thursday close of ₹73.50 on NSE. REUTERS

Zee Entertainment Enterprises Ltd has approved a ₹600 crore share buyback at ₹91 apiece, offering investors a premium of more than 23% to the stock's last closing price. The move comes as the company seeks to restore investor confidence amid concerns over its growth prospects and profitability.

The buyback price represents a 23.8% premium to Zee Entertainment's closing price of ₹73.50 on the National Stock Exchange on Thursday. Announced after market hours, the buyback will cover 6.86% of the company's paid-up equity, Zee said in a press release. The company's promoters, the Goenka family and related entities, will not participate in the buyback. Together, they hold a 3.99% stake in Zee Entertainment.

"The Board recognized the buy-back as an optimal approach to reward the shareholders, as well as reinstate confidence in its robust fundamentals and strategic road map for the future," the company said in the statement.

"The Board believes that the Company's intrinsic value is not appropriately reflected in its current market valuation, and the buy-back represents a prudent opportunity to reinforce confidence in the Company's capabilities to generate long-term value for shareholders," chairman R. Gopalan added. Zee's largest non-promoter shareholders include state-owned insurer Life Insurance Corp. of India (LIC), foreign portfolio investors (FPIs), including Vanguard, and individual shareholders, who collectively hold more than 37% of the company. The latter category comprises investors holding shares worth up to ₹2 lakh each.

Zee's promoters, the Goenka family and related entities, holding 3.99%, will not participate in the buyback

In July, the Goenka family proposed investing ₹3,143 crore in Zee through fully convertible warrants priced at ₹126 apiece, which would raise their stake to as much as 25%. The investment was proposed to be completed within 18 months of the subscription date.

Zee reported cash and cash equivalents of ₹2,570 crore as of September 2026. Its operating revenue rose 13% year-on-year to ₹1,969.2 crore in the September quarter, while net profit fell 40% to ₹76.5 crore.

Advertising revenue remained flat at around ₹800 crore, weighed down by weakness in linear television. Subscription revenue, however, grew 30% year-on-year to ₹1,332 crore.

In June, Zee secured comprehensive eight-year rights to the Fifa World Cup and related properties for an estimated $30 million, *Mint* reported.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Rupee rebound lifts dollar returns on stocks

Srushti Vaidya & Ram Sahgal
MUMBAI

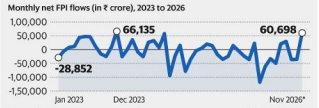
A surge in foreign inflows has helped the rupee recover, boosting returns on Indian equities in dollar terms relative to those in rupee terms and reversing a prolonged period of underperformance for overseas investors. The Nifty 50 rose 11% in dollar terms between 30 October and 11 November, compared with a 9.5% gain in rupee terms. Dollar returns matter particularly to foreign investors, who had turned cautious on India amid subdued market performance, with the rupee's depreciation further eroding their returns when converted into dollars.

In the year through 30 October, the Nifty 50 delivered negative dollar returns of 16.77%, significantly worse than its 10.92% decline in rupee terms. That trend has reversed since 30 October, with dollar returns now outpacing rupee returns.

Foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) have net bought shares worth ₹60,698 crore in the first 11 days of November, the highest monthly inflow so far since December 2023, NSDL data. FPIs stepped up their purchases in Indian markets from 30 October and market participants expect FPI purchases to gather further momentum in the coming weeks. A cooling AI trade in the US and easing oil prices, following Republican losses in the midterm elections, have also improved the appeal of Indian equities. The rupee has appreciated 1.5% since 30 October to ₹93.69 against the dollar as of 11 November, recovering after touching record lows earlier this year.

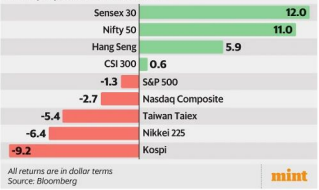
Flow back

Monthly net FPI flows (in ₹ crore), 2023 to 2026



Source: NSDL *Till 11 November

Return (in %), 30 October to 11 November



All returns are in dollar terms
Source: Bloomberg

SATISH KUMAR/MINT

The current inflows into India could be driven by investors covering their India 'anti-AI' short positions, as global and emerging-market funds rebalance their underweight allocations to the country, said Arvind Chari, chief investment strategist at Q India UK, an affiliate of Quantum Advisors India that helps foreign investors allocate money to India.

Rupee depreciation had further eroded foreign investors' dollar returns amid weak markets

The clinching factor for the rupee is the recent FPI inflow. If crude trends below $100 per barrel, the rupee could appreciate to as much as 93 to the dollar by the year-end, said Madan Sabnavis, chief economist at Bank of Baroda. The downside, however, could be limited to around 95 if FPI flows weaken or oil prices rise to $100 in the near term, he added.

A stronger economy and improving corporate earnings attract foreign investors, supporting capital inflows and the rupee.

The return of foreign money to India comes amid a correction in global artificial intelligence (AI) stocks, which had attracted significant investor interest.

The benchmark Nifty 50 has delivered 11.02% in dollar returns since 30 October, outperforming major global markets, including the US, Japan, Hong Kong and South Korea, which have posted negative returns in the same period, according to *Bloomberg* data. MSCI World Index has delivered -1% returns.

In the US, the AI-heavy Nasdaq 100 and S&P 500 indices have fallen 2.74% and 1.31%, respectively, since 30 October. Markets with greater exposure to individual AI-linked stocks have seen steeper declines, with South Korea's Kospi and Taiwan's Taiex falling 9.4% and 4.5% in dollar terms.

"The AI trade, to my mind, has peaked for now, and so whenever there is a rally, there will be caution on that trade," said Nirmal Jain, founder of the IIFL Group. This could channel more durable FPI inflows into India. Alongside a decline in crude oil prices, that would provide further support to the rupee and create a virtuous cycle of stronger foreign investor returns, Jain added.

FPI inflows into India could sustain as investors remain significantly underweight on the country, said Jay Kothari, global head of international business at DSP Mutual Fund. Even a shift from an underweight to a neutral allocation could bring in an additional $20-30 billion, of which around $3-4 billion has already started flowing in, he added.

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Jewellers' gain masks gold volume dip

Vaeshnavi Kasthuril & Neethi Lisa Rojan
BENGALURU/MUMBAI

Gold jewellery demand by volume fell 20% year-on-year in the quarter, even as the value of jewellery demand increased 16%. MINT

Organised jewellery retailers reported strong revenue growth in the September quarter (Q2FY27), but higher gold prices continued to mask weakness in the volume of gold consumers are buying.

India's gold jewellery demand by volume fell 20% year-on-year in the quarter, even as the value of jewellery demand increased 16%, according to the World Gold Council. Consumers are spending more on jewellery but buying less gold by weight.

The trend is expected to continue through the current fiscal year. Crisil Ratings expects revenue of organised jewellery retailers to grow 21-23% in FY27, even as sales volumes decline 4-6%. Gold prices are expected to average 25-27% higher than the previous fiscal year, supporting revenue growth despite weaker demand by volume. The price of 24K gold fell from ₹1,63,437 per 10 grams on 24 August to ₹1,38,192 on 12 November.

That pullback was driven by hotter US inflation and strong jobs data, which fuelled expectations that the Federal Reserve would hold or raise interest rates. Higher Treasury yields and a stronger dollar made non-yielding bullion less attractive compared with interest-bearing assets, while profit-booking, exchange-traded fund (ETF) outflows and broader equity-market selling added to the pressure.

Titan Co. Ltd reported 24% year-on-year growth in its jewellery business to ₹17,495 crore in Q2FY27, excluding bullion and digital gold. Kalyan Jewellers Ltd reported a 32% increase in consolidated revenue to ₹10,323 crore. Kalyan reported same-store sales growth of about 20% in the quarter, while Titan did not disclose same-store sales growth.

The price of 24K gold fell from ₹1,63,437 per 10 grams on 24 August to ₹1,38,192 on 12 November

BlueStone's earnings before interest, tax, depreciation and amortisation (Ebitda) more than doubled in Q2FY27, marking its fourth consecutive profitable quarter on a standalone basis. Revenue from operations rose 43% to ₹738 crore in the quarter.

With gold prices remaining elevated, retailers are seeing consumers prioritize design, variety and affordability. This is driving a shift toward lighter pieces, studded jewellery and products across price points.

"We have seen fantastic growth at a consolidated level across most of our brands and businesses...driven, of course, by a lot of focus on innovation and prioritizing growth over everything else, given the opportunity that India offers," Ajoy Chawla, managing director of Titan, said on 5 November.

The company also sees gold exchange as an important tool to sustain purchases. "One is the whole gold exchange programme, which is a huge lever, and as you are aware, we have been at it for the last one year, and that is something that is giving us good results," Arun Narayan, chief executive of Titan's jewellery division, said on 5 November. Narayan said the retailer's role was to offer customers a choice. "It is a long-term strategic decision we have taken, and we would like to stick with it," he added.

Kalyan Jewellers is using cash-for-gold programmes alongside traditional exchange to protect margins. Ramesh Kalyanaraman, executive director of the company, said gold-for-cash transactions accounted for 7-8% of the business, taking the overall exchange share to 42%. This helped keep margins stable in Q2, he said on 11 November.

The shift towards affordability is visible in the products manufacturers are making. Sky Gold & Diamonds Ltd said consumers are increasingly moving from 22-karat jewellery to lower-karat options.

"Every quarter, we are seeing that there's a drastic change in the karatage shift from 22-karat to 18-karat to 14-karat and 9-karat. So, 100% there is a shift...youngsters want to buy lower karatage at a very decent budget," Mangesh Chauhan, Sky Gold managing director, said on 31 October.

BlueStone is expanding its range across price points as it seeks to widen its customer base. "A million customers teach you things no survey ever can, and we closely watch what they want on our own platform. The clearest lesson is that today's customer wants to feel elegant and aspirational, and wants her jewellery to do that for her," Gaurav Singh Kushwaha, founder and chief executive of BlueStone, said on 23 October.

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Norwest's $4 bn fund targets healthcare, AI

Norwest will deepen investments and take portfolio companies public

Mansi Verma & Sneha Shah
MUMBAI

Niren Shah, managing director and head of India at Norwest Venture Partners, says the firm plans to invest $250-300 million annually in India.

Norwest Venture Partners, a multi-stage investment firm, plans to deploy a 'significant' part of its newly raised $4-billion fund in Indian opportunities across value-added manufacturing, healthcare, pharma, financial services and consumer.

"The fund is a global fund, so there is no specific allocation to India. But Norwest continues to be very bullish on India," Niren Shah, managing director and head of India at Norwest said in an interview with *Mint*. "Over time, Norwest has developed a deep understanding of India and continues to believe strongly in its prospects for the foreseeable future."

The firm, which has backed companies such as Swiggy, Expressbees, Ofbusiness, Mintify, among others, will "continue to invest in India at a very significant pace of $250-300 million a year", Shah added.

After raising its largest-ever fund, Norwest's total capital under management stands at $18 billion. The firm, which is celebrating its twentieth year of investing in India, is looking to add value-added manufacturing and manufacturing-related services as a thesis to its investment strategy.

"This is something that has started over the last year, and I think we will continue to increase our investments in this area. The increase in the fund size is also a representation of the opportunity," Shah added.

Norwest invests in early, growth and buyout opportunities in the US, India and Israel.

From its 17th fund of $3 billion, the firm has invested in companies such as Padmini VNA in automotive and JJG Aerospace, Shah said. "Even now, there are multiple investments at the final stages that are related to these segments."

Apart from manufacturing, Norwest is also focusing on healthcare, AI and deep-tech, financial services and consumer businesses.

"AI and deep tech are more of a venture theme, although most of our other investments are in growth equity. We also made investments in AI and deep tech in the last fund, such as Pascal AI, where we see a strong focus on AI coming from India, for India or for global markets."

Shah believes India has several promising AI and deeptech companies, despite perceptions that the country is lagging in the global AI race. He said these businesses need greater visibility as well as investment. "We are starting to do that. And I think this will also come of age. When we were doing internet, everyone said, "Oh, India will not have internet; it will all be offline." That's not true. Yeah, sometimes it's running two years behind, but that story will happen. I think some of these narratives will change," he said.

"Maybe LLMs have made a big noise, and maybe one category you could argue is well suited to some other countries. But the rest of AI is going to proliferate quite rapidly, and I think to that extent, Indian AI companies will also exist and thrive and be very large," he added.

The firm has been harvesting some of its older bets in India too. In the last two decades, it has seen 30 exits from portfolio companies. "Of those, 10 have gone public through IPOs, which is a significant number."

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NORWEST BETS

NORWEST raises its largest-ever $4 bn fund, taking assets under management to $18 bn

THE firm has recorded 30 exits from its Indian portfolio over two decades

FOUR portfolio companies are preparing to file for IPOs within the next six months

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EXTRACT OF STATEMENT OF FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER AND HALF YEAR ENDED 30TH SEPTEMBER 2026

(Rs. in Crores)

		Standalone			Consolidated		
		3 months ended 30.09.2026 Unaudited	6 months ended 30.09.2026 Unaudited	3 months ended 30.09.2025 Unaudited	3 months ended 30.09.2026 Unaudited	6 months ended 30.09.2026 Unaudited	3 months ended 30.09.2025 Unaudited
1	Total Income from operations	664.81	1,322.81	571.55	730.53	1,428.47	632.70
2	Net Profit/(Loss) before tax (before Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	155.31	325.03	141.12	184.29	353.60	158.02
3	Net Profit/(Loss) before tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	155.31	325.03	149.53	184.29	353.60	166.43
4	Net Profit/(Loss) after tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	117.20	244.29	103.47	141.46	261.77	116.56
5	Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit / (Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	114.28	241.16	101.92	153.22	272.49	141.44
6	Paid-up Equity Share Capital (Face Value - Rs. 2 each)	125.07	125.07	125.07	125.07	125.07	125.07
7	Other Equity (excluding Revaluation Reserve) in the audited Balance Sheet as at 31 March 2026		4,563.61			5,137.21	
8	Earnings per Equity Share on net profit after tax (fully paid up equity share of Rs. 2 each):						
	(a) Basic	1.88	3.91	1.66	2.18	4.05	1.82
	(b) Diluted	1.88	3.91	1.66	2.18	4.05	1.82

NOTES:

1 The above is an extract of the detailed format of the Quarterly Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Statement of Financial Results is available on the Stock Exchange websites, www.bseindia.com, www.nseindia.com and on the Company's website, www.eihltd.com. The same can be accessed by scanning the QR code provided alongside.

2 The above financial results have been reviewed by the Audit Committee and approved by the Board of Directors at the meetings held on 12th November 2026.

3 The statutory auditors have carried out a limited review of these financial results.

VIKRAMJIT SINGH OBEROI
Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer
(DIN: 00052014)

Mumbai
12th November 2026

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UN-AUDITED STANDALONE AND CONSOLIDATED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER AND HALF YEAR ENDED 30TH SEPTEMBER 2026

The Board of Directors of the Company, at its meeting held on Thursday, November 12, 2026, approved the Un-Audited Financial Results (Standalone and Consolidated) of the Company for the quarter and half year ended 30th September 2026.

The complete Financial Results, along with the Limited Review Report of the Statutory Auditors, are available on the Company's website at https://mallcom.in/pages/investor-relations and can be accessed by scanning the QR code provided.

Scan to view results

For Mallcom (India) Limited
Sd/-
Ajay Kumar Mall
Managing Director
DIN 00470184

Place: Kolkata
Date: November 12, 2026

MALLCOM (INDIA) LIMITED
Regd. Office: Mallcom Tower, EN-12, Sector-V, Salt Lake City, Kolkata-700 091 | +91 33 4016 1000 | investors@mallcom.in | CIN: L51109WB1983PLC037008

www.mallcom.in

Blackstone seen as frontrunner for BluPine

FROM PAGE 1

spread across the country as part of its expansion.

Led by Neerav Nanavaty, the Gurugram-based company develops, builds, owns and operates renewable energy projects across India. It has expanded its C&I business through customized renewable energy solutions using captive, group captive and open-access models, helping businesses across sectors meet their sustainability and decarbonization goals.

Actis is a global infrastructure investor with a track record of building businesses and operating assets across markets. It has deployed more than $7.1 billion across different investment strategies in Asia. The firm has built or operated more than 8GW of installed energy capacity in the region, including over 5.5GW of renewable energy capacity.

Blackstone, meanwhile, has stepped up efforts to build a large infrastructure portfolio in India. The firm recently hired Ami Momaya from KKR to lead its infrastructure investment team in the country. Blackstone is looking to deploy nearly $100 billion in India by 2047, with infrastructure among its key investment themes.

India plans to add 1,800GW of renewable energy capacity by 2047 and 5,000GW by 2070, *Mint* reported in November. Industry executives say acquisitions and other forms of inorganic expansion are increasingly becoming a preferred route to growth in the energy sector.

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Tata Steel targets 10 mt of local iron ore sales this year

The firm is looking to monetize surplus mining capacity while ensuring adequate supplies

Dipali Banka & Nehal Chaliawala
MUMBAI

Tata Steel Ltd is stepping up sales of iron ore to the domestic market, targeting 10 million tonnes (mt) this fiscal year from about 2 mt in the previous one, as it looks to monetize surplus mining capacity while ensuring adequate supplies for its expanding steelmaking operations.

India's largest steelmaker, which has invested in expanding its iron ore production and processing capacity over the past three to four years, said it was on track to achieve the higher sales target. The move follows regulatory changes that removed restrictions on selling iron ore from captive mines, allowing steel producers to supply the domestic market.

With current annual iron ore production exceeding 48 mt, the steelmaker has ample surplus after meeting its internal requirements. "We have iron ore in excess of about 48 mt at this point of time. We are using the iron ore for 100% our own needs... once the regulatory bar has been taken out... we are also supplying to the Indian market," Koushik Chatterjee, executive director and chief financial officer of Tata Steel, said in an interview with *Mint*.

Chatterjee said the additional supplies would also help address shortages faced by pellet manufacturers in Odisha, some of whose plants were not operating due to inadequate iron ore availability.

Last year's sales were constrained by production and dispatch bottlenecks, which the company has since worked to resolve. Beyond this fiscal year's 10-million-tonne target, Tata Steel expects commercial volumes to rise further over the next couple of years, depending on the surplus left after meeting its internal requirements.

"First priority is to consume what we need and what is in excess, we will sell," said T.V. Narendran, managing director and chief executive at Tata Steel, adding that the company would not compromise supplies to its own steelmaking operations to increase merchant sales.

The increased iron ore sales are designed to support Tata Steel's core steelmaking business rather than create an independent revenue stream. According to Chatterjee, the added earnings are a natural outcome of making surplus ore available to the domestic market.

The strategy is also part of a broader effort to prepare Tata Steel's cost structure for the next decade, as existing captive mining leases expire after 2030 and raw material sourcing requirements shift. To reduce sole reliance on captive mines and improve blast furnace productivity, the company is evaluating flexible iron ore blends, including imports of higher-grade, low-alumina ore.

Indian iron ore is relatively cheaper but has higher alumina content, which can affect furnace efficiency and increase consumption costs. Tata Steel has started importing ore from Canada and is evaluating supplies from other sources, including Australia.

Tata Steel is also targeting annual cost savings of ₹5,000-10,000 crore in India through operational efficiencies, improvements in coal consumption, leaner raw material blends, and lower maintenance costs.

The company achieved cost savings of about ₹11,000 crore across geographies in the previous fiscal year and has budgeted around ₹7,100 crore for the current year. The top executives clarified that these figures include savings across its global operations and should not be interpreted as an equivalent annual increase in earnings.

"In India, I would say going to 2030, there are multiple levers we are working on. One is cost takeout, and typically in India for us, anything from ₹7,000 crore to ₹10,000 crore a year is a standard target through KPI (key performance indicators) improvement," Narendran said.

Beyond cost reduction, Tata Steel is working to boost realizations by increasing its share of value-added and downstream products. Its consumer-facing Tata Tiscon brand, for example, commands higher prices than comparable business-to-business offerings.

In Europe, however, the turnaround remains more challenging as the company grapples with regulatory uncertainty in the Netherlands and weak volumes in the UK.

At its Netherlands operations, Tata Steel is in talks with the government regarding the regulatory framework and conditions required to continue operating in the country.

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Koushik Chatterjee, executive director and chief financial officer of Tata Steel.

MINE STORY

INDIA's largest steelmaker said it was on track to achieve the higher sales target

THE move follows regulatory changes that removed curbs on selling iron ore from captive mines

THE steelmaker's current annual iron ore production exceeds 48 million tonnes

ADDITIONAL supplies would help address shortages faced by pellet makers in Odisha

MOVES

A weekly list of C-Suiters who have moved up the corporate ladder either within or outside their companies.

Aditya Deshpande	Appointed as **managing director and India head—private banking** at **Standard Chartered**
Ashish Sardesai	Appointed as **managing director and chief executive officer** at **Centrico Insurance**
Ashutosh Bhargava	Appointed as **chief executive officer** at **Neo Mutual Fund**
Deepak K. Khare	Appointed as **chief operating officer** at **Exide Energy Solutions**
Diptangshu Chatterjee	Appointed as **chief financial officer and director** at **BC Jindal Group**
Dr Kuber Jagdale	Appointed as **chief technical officer and executive director** at **Cohance Lifesciences**
Natarajan Ramasubramanian	Appointed as **chief financial officer and vice president—finance and controlling** at **Sulzer Pumps India**
Parveen Mahtani	Appointed as **group head—legal** at **The Phoenix Mills**
Pranav Komerwar	Appointed as **chief executive officer** at **Avaada Electro**
Priyank Jain	Appointed as **chief financial officer** at **Jeena & Co.**
Saurabh Arora	Appointed as **head of human resources—India** at **Franklin Templeton**
Shilpa Marodia	Appointed as **marketing director—India and South Asia** at **Lenovo**
Sudeep Agrawal	Appointed as **group chief financial officer** at **CKA Birla Group**
Vivek Singhal	Appointed as **chief executive officer** at **Hindustan Construction Co.**

Source: Accord India, executive search worldwide

The development comes amid steadily rising investor interest in the mother-and-child care market. HT

Private equity funds eye Ankura's $100 mn round

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MUMBAI

Ankura Hospitals, which specializes in maternity and paediatric care, is attracting interest from several large private equity funds, including General Atlantic, Goldman Sachs Private Equity and Motilal Oswal Alternates, for its ongoing $100 million fundraise, two people familiar with the matter said. "The company has roped in Alvarez & Marsal as an advisor to help with the process," one these people said, adding that the fundraise has garnered significant interest from private equity funds on the back of growing demand for its services.

The development comes nearly two years after Ankura Hospitals raised funds to expand its operations

"The round will be a combination of primary and secondary share sale by existing investors including some angel investors and InvAscent, who may exit in part or full," a second person said. Both people spoke on the condition of anonymity as the discussions are still confidential.

Goldman Sachs and General Atlantic declined to comment, while Ankura, InvAscent, A&M and Motilal Oswal Alternates did not respond to *Mint*'s requests for comment.

The development comes nearly two years after the Hyderabad-based company raised funds to expand its operations. It also comes amid steadily rising investor interest in the mother-and-child care market, driven by population growth, greater awareness, policy support and increased healthcare spending.

Mint first reported the launch of the fundraise in January. The potential transaction may allow InvAscent to monetize its seven-year-old stake in the company. Ankura last raised ₹165 crore from the Asian Development Bank in March 2025 to strengthen its market presence. At the time, the company outlined plans to establish new facilities in key cities across India.

Ankura Medical & Research Centre Pvt. Ltd, the legal entity that operates the chain, posted consolidated revenue of ₹376 crore in FY24, according to Tracxn data. The company was last valued at ₹877 crore as of last year, according to the data platform.

Founded in 2011 by Krishna Prasad Rao Vunnam, Ankura Hospitals began with the aim of providing childcare and eventually grew into a network specialising in several areas, including paediatrics, neonatology, maternity and gynaecology. The company has more than 19 centres across five states.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Nvidia India staff lose $570 mn on paper

FROM PAGE 1

6.25% every three months after that, according to information the chipmaker gave to the US Securities and Exchange Commission.

While the total value mentioned above is for shares not yet credited, some employees must have received some of their RSUs during this time, possibly affecting their earnings during India's main festive season.

On an average, every $10 drop in Nvidia's share price reduces the valuation of stocks to be received by its Indian workforce by a total of about $70 million.

The biggest impact could be on the long-serving employees at Nvidia India, which had 5,590 employees at the end of March 2026. *Mint* could not determine how many of its India staff qualify for RSUs.

The impact of the share price fall depends on when employees received their shares and whether they held on to them.

Nvidia is the world leader in graphic processing units. AP

Assuming 6.25% of the shares are credited to employees' accounts every three months, the last two such releases would have been in the weeks starting 17 June and 16 September, when Nvidia shares traded at $204.42 and $213.90, respectively. Employees who retained these shares would have paid tax on their value when they were credited. Since then, the shares have lost about 17% and 21% of their value, respectively.

The next vesting round is likely in the week of 9 December. Before that, Nvidia will report its next global quarterly earnings on 17 November, which will be closely watched by the market.

A senior executive, who has been with Nvidia India for over a decade, was not unduly worried. "Most of us who sell our shares over the years do so for big life events: buying a house, a wedding, and so on. So, fewer people would be affected right away, and they probably saw their shares grow a lot over the years. Only their recent gains would have been lost."

Every $10 drop in Nvidia stock cuts the valuation of shares to be received by its Indian workforce by about $70 mn

"That's the thing about share prices—they bounce back," the executive said on the condition of anonymity.

This loss in value follows an extraordinary run, especially since FY22. A Mint review of nine years of filings from Nvidia's Indian unit shows employees received about $3.1 billion (over ₹25,000 crore) worth of Nvidia shares between FY18 and FY26, valued on the days they vested.

Nvidia is seen by industry stakeholders to be "the most stable among all the US AI companies," said Jayanth Kolla, co-founder of Convergence Catalyst, an enterprise AI solutions firm. "It has been four years since generative AI became mainstream, and we have not seen a broad-based threat to Nvidia's dominance in the AI compute market," Kolla said. "Unless there is an extreme circumstance in which Huang is removed from the company or the espionage claims are substantiated further, Nvidia is likely to bounce back first from the current dip."

Oil India's profit more than doubles

Reuters
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Oil India on Thursday reported a second-quarter profit that more than doubled, helped by higher realizations amid a spike in global crude oil prices.

The state-owned oil exploration firm's standalone profit, which excludes profit from its joint ventures (JVs) and operations outside India, rose to ₹2,259 crore ($241.24 million) for the quarter ended 30 September, from ₹1,044 crore a year ago.

The state-owned oil exploration firm's standalone profit rose to ₹2,259 crore for the quarter ended 30 September

Crude oil realization climbed 35% to $92.24 per barrel from $68.19 per barrel a year earlier.

The company's net profit margin expanded to 27.99% from 19.13% a year earlier.

Revenue from operations of the company rose 48% to ₹8,071 crore.

Elara Capital analysts expected Oil India and other producers to benefit from stronger crude realizations, driven by elevated oil prices and a weaker rupee amid West Asia supply disruptions.

Benchmark Brent crude prices averaged nearly 40% higher year-on-year during the quarter.

Total expenses increased 21.7% to 60.49 billion rupees.

Last week, peer Oil and Natural Gas Corp. Ltd reported a 57.3% increase in profit.

SpiceJet running late on flights, supplier payments, salaries

FROM PAGE 1

shrinking footprint.

Its domestic market share fell to a record low of 0.6% in September, below regional carrier Star Air's 0.7%. Just nine of its 12 aircraft are flying; the other three remain grounded as the Ajay Singh-promoted airline struggles to pay rent to lessors.

SpiceJet's half-yearly report submitted to the corporate affairs ministry on 30 October shows that 51.3% or ₹63.03 crore of the ₹122.93 crore owed to small businesses remained unpaid for more than 45 days in April-September 2026.

The airline paid ₹54.77 crore within 45 days, and another ₹5.13 crore remained unpaid but was not yet overdue.

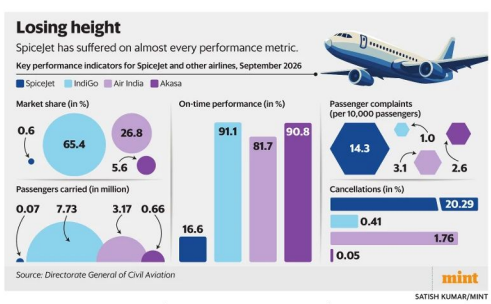
The problem is widespread. A total of 7,660 invoices went unpaid over the past 45 days, making up 85.4% of all invoices, the highest share in at least two years.

On-time payments, meanwhile, dropped to their lowest level in two years, about 60% lower than the ₹135.61 crore that SpiceJet paid on time in October 2024-March 2025.

The airline was in a worse position in April-September 2024, when it had ₹94.14 crore in overdue payments, accounting for about 53% of its total micro, small and medium enterprises (MSME) dues.

The airline has cited the same reason for almost every overdue entry: "Invoice received late."

Under the Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises Development (MSMED) Act, 2006, buyers must pay MSMEs within 45 days; otherwise, they owe compound interest at three times the bank rate notified by the central Bank.



SATISH KUMAR/MINT

"At present, SpiceJet has been able to make timely payments to oil marketing companies, which has allowed it to continue scheduling flights and selling tickets. While the airline is not insolvent, rising supplier dues, increase in cancellations, customer complaints, and delayed salary payments point to clear signs of financial strain," said Abhinil Dahiwale, research analyst at Elara Capital.

"The airline is in desperate need of investors and a cash infusion," he added.

The payment delays come as SpiceJet struggles to restore its financial health.

The airline has not yet shared its results for the March quarter, the full year ended March 2026, the June quarter and the September quarter.

It last reported a net loss of ₹262 crore in the December quarter of fiscal year 2025-26 (FY26), after a ₹621 crore loss in the previous quarter.

CareEdge Ratings lowered the airline's long-term bank rating to B- in April 2026, citing ongoing losses, a weak financial state, and tight cash flow. Its total debt was ₹4,218.5 crore as of March 2025, including ₹3,329.3 crore in lease payments owed.

Mint's queries emailed to SpiceJet, ministry of corporate affairs and the DGCA remained unanswered.

SpiceJet carried about 73,000 domestic passengers in September, compared to 592,000 in January, as its market share fell from 3.9% to 0.6%, according to DGCA data.

The cancellation rate rose from 1.44% in January to 20.29% in September, the highest among all carriers, and more than 17 times the industry average of 1.15%.

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For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Audit, advisory firms roll out 10-15% pay hikes, bonuses

Firms are trying to retain employees to prepare for next round of mandatory audit rotations.

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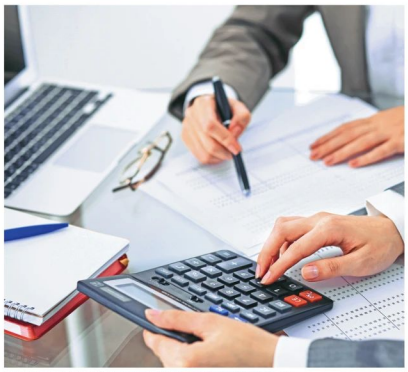
MUMBAI



The firms are also getting employees to rework their skill sets. ISTOCKPHOTO

Retention is the keyword for audit and advisory firms this year.

They rolled out neat 10-15% increments this year, apart from bonuses, special monetary rewards and promotions. While the raises are in line with what the firms offered last year, top performers in some cases received hikes of 25-28%.

The increments come as firms try to retain employees and expand their teams to prepare for the next round of mandatory audit rotations. The firms are also getting the workforce to rework their skill sets as artificial intelligence (AI) becomes an integral tool, noting that going ahead, billing and compensation will be linked to how employees use AI tools.

"If firms are rolling out a 25%-plus increase in salaries, then they are doing it for retention," said Roopank Chaudhary, partner and rewards consulting leader, talent solutions, India, for Aon. "This also comes at a time when the sector including top firms and other audit firms have seen attrition which can in some teams touch 20%."

"Overall payouts have remained broadly in line with the previous year. Increments have been in the range of 10-15%, while bonuses have largely been in the 15-20% range," said Arti Dua, a partner and national talent leader at EY India. "Promotions have also remained at levels comparable with the past few years, covering nearly 20% of our workforce."

EY is one of the Big Four in India, a clutch of top audit and advisory firms. EY's rivals are Deloitte, PwC and KPMG. Some in this group, such as EY, have 50,000-60,000 employees, so a back-of-the-envelope calculation would put the number of promotions at 10,000-12,000.

More than 600 companies will be required to change their auditors in the next round of mandatory rotation starting in 2027. The rotation of auditors, which took effect in 2017, was introduced as a regulatory safeguard aimed at preventing long-term familiarity between an auditor and the company management.

Audit firms, both big and small, are retaining their key talent and ensuring there is no dip in increment numbers. Even niche firms have had to offer generous hikes to hold on to their talent as they vie for a larger slice of the client pie during the upcoming audit rotation.

"We rolled out a 15-20% hike this year versus 10-15% last year. The need to retain top talent when there is high attrition in the industry is one of the main reasons for this hike," said S. Ravi, founder of Ravi Rajan & Co LLP, a boutique chartered accountancy firm based in New Delhi with a team of over 200 professionals. The trump card for such firms is a smaller but more consistent team, not typically vulnerable to partner poaching and not cross-selling other services alongside audit.

Even for employees who are not in audit teams but work in technology, cyber security, risk and compliance, the demand for specialists is high as clients work through changes around AI, risk management and digital threats.

Deloitte India's spokesperson said the firm promoted 15% of its workforce in June this year, "marginally up" from last year in both absolute and percentage terms. Given the firm's 50,000 workforce, the number of promotions would be roughly 7,500.

"Performance bonuses were paid out as per schedule in September and approximately 1,000 were given a 'President's Bonus' – an extra bonus awarded by business heads to nominated professionals," the company said.

Mint learnt that Deloitte rolled out an 8-12% hike this year and top performers received 25-28%, but the firm did not comment on these numbers.

Hikes and bonuses are typically paid out in the May-September period for advisory firms, which handle audit and consulting as well.

Mint learnt that PwC gave out 9-14% hikes this year, almost the same range last year. The bonuses were equivalent to 10-14% of an employee's cost to the company, but the top performers got more than double that amount.

Both PwC and KPMG did not respond to *Mint*'s queries.

On the heels of the Big Four are two others: BDO India and Grant Thornton Bharat. BDO India said it gave hikes of 11-14% over the past three years, with average bonus payouts of about 10% of fixed pay.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

RISING COMPENSATION

HIKES and bonuses are typically paid out in the May-September period for advisory firms

OVER 600 firms will need to change their auditors in the next mandatory rotation round starting in 2027

AUDIT firms are retaining their key talent and ensuring there is no dip in increment numbers

EVEN niche firms have made generous hikes to hold on to talent as they vie for a larger client share

Exide, Amara Raja rush to monetize $1 bn battery bets

Ayaan Kartik
ayaan.kartik@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

Both firms are awaiting large orders from automakers, despite securing preliminary tie-ups with Hyundai-Kia and Ather. MINT

India's top battery makers, Exide Industries Ltd and Amara Raja Energy & Mobility Ltd, are rushing to operationalize their lithium-ion cell lines amid investor pressure over returns on more than $1 billion in investments. Exide has invested $632 million so far, while Amara Raja has deployed $248 million and approved an additional $247 million this month. The push comes as both firms await large orders from car and two-wheeler makers, despite having secured preliminary tie-ups with Hyundai-Kia and Ather.

The two companies are taking distinct paths to generate early revenue from their plants. Exide is starting with cells for electric rickshaws and telecom towers, while Amara Raja is focusing on battery energy storage system (BESS) projects.

The delay in electric vehicle (EV) programmes has increased pressure on both companies, as Exide had planned to start the first 6GWh of its cell plant by FY25 but only did so in September 2026. Amara Raja, which had earlier expected commercial cell production by FY26, is now targeting Q2FY28 for its first 2GWh line.

Exide is starting with cells for e-rickshaws and telecom towers, while Amara Raja is focusing on BESS projects

Amara Raja shares are down 18% so far this year while Exide shares are up 6%. The Nifty Auto index has gained 0.15% over this period.

For Exide, initial revenue is coming from lithium iron phosphate (LFP) cells, which require shorter approval cycles than the nickel manganese cobalt (NMC) cells common in electric two-wheelers. The company is deploying its 102Ah LFP cells in its own e-rickshaw battery packs and has dispatched samples to telecom operators.

Lithium ion cells that power electric vehicles are mostly imported from China. LFP cells are cheaper and longer-lasting, while NMC cells perform better but do not last as long as LFP cells.

Exide managing director and chief executive Avik Roy said the company started earning revenue from LFP cells in October, while its NMC cells are still being tested by customers.

"Performance testing has been very satisfactory. We got positive feedback," Roy said during the company's earnings call on 5 November. "Lifecycle testing takes time, and once lifecycle testing is over, they will do the pack and the vehicle-level testing. That is the next phase."

Amara Raja, meanwhile, plans to start commercial operations in BESS before its EV cell business begins. The company has finished checking its machines at its 5GWh pack assembly plant and expects test runs in December, followed by commercial operations in January or February.

"We don't foresee a challenge with respect to utilization of the plant," chief financial officer Y. Delli Babu said, pointing to demand from grid-scale storage and commercial and industrial customers. The company expects to use 50-60% of the facility's capacity in FY28 and reach full utilization by FY29.

Its cell program remains at the customer approval stage. Amara Raja has made nearly 2,000 NMC cells at its customer qualification plant, which are being tested internally. Delli Babu said the company expects to send samples to potential original equipment manufacturers (OEMs) in the next few months. LFP cells are still being developed.

Both companies are building bigger manufacturing plants while trying to earn money soon from other uses. Exide has started a 6GWh lithium-ion cell plant in Bengaluru, while Amara Raja is developing its Giga Corridor in Divitipally, Telangana. Its bigger plan includes 16GWh of cell capacity and 5GWh of pack assembly.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

INDIAN RAILWAY CATERING AND TOURISM CORPORATION LTD.
(A Government of India Enterprise - Navratna)
CIN - L74899DL1999GOI101707

UN-AUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS (STANDALONE & CONSOLIDATED) FOR THE QUARTER AND HALF YEAR ENDED ON SEPTEMBER 30, 2026

The Board of Directors of the Company, on the recommendations of the Audit Committee, at its meeting held on Thursday, November 12, 2026 has approved the Un-Audited Financial Results for the quarter and half year ended on September 30, 2026.

The aforesaid Financial Results, along with the Limited Review Report, have been uploaded on the Company's website and websites of BSE and NSE. The same is available at [https://www.irctc.com/assets/images2/OutcomeMeetingBoardDirectors12Nov2026.pdf] and can be accessed by scanning the QR code.

For & on behalf of the Board of Directors
Sd/-
Rahul Himalian
Chairman & Managing Director
DIN: 10393348

Place: New Delhi
Dated: 12th November, 2026

Note: The above intimation is in accordance with Regulation 33 read with Regulation 47 (1) of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015.

IRCTC Limited, 4th Floor, Tower-D, World Trade Centre, Nauroji Nagar, New Delhi-110029

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CIN: L74899DL1971PLC009720
Regd. Office: 6, Community Centre, Saket, New Delhi 110017
Tele: 011-26857338
E-mail: share.dept@unitechgroup.com | Web: www.unitechgroup.com

Statement of Un-audited Financial Results (Standalone and Consolidated) for the quarter&half year ended 30th September, 2026

The Board of Directors of the Company at its meeting held on 12th November, 2026, approved the Un-audited Financial Results (Standalone and Consolidated), for the quarter & half year ended 30th September, 2026.
The investors can access the financial results alongwith Auditor's Review reports on Company's website at https://www.unitechgroup.com/investor-relations/financial.asp and stock exchanges websites at www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com.
Further, the full financial results can also be accessed by scanning the Quick Response Code (QR) provided herein.

For more information, please scan

Note: The above intimation is in accordance with Regulation 33 read with Regulation 47(1) of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015.

For Unitech Limited
Sd/-
Giridhar Aramane
Chairman & Managing Director

Place: Gurugram
Dated: 12th November, 2026

Hindustan Times FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

EVERYONE HAS A THEORY OURS HAS THE NUMBERS

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Syama Prasad Mookerjee Port, Kolkata
(Formerly KOLKATA PORT TRUST)

E-Tender No. : 2026_KoPT_929729_1
Development of Drainage Master Plan at Industrial & Railway Zone (IZ&R), H.D.C., Haldia
Estimated Cost : ₹ 24,27,43,096.06 (excluding GST)
Last Date of submission: 25.11.2026 upto 15.00 hrs. | Bidding through : https://eprocure.gov.in/eprocure/app

Tender No. SDM(P&E)/T/22/2026-27
GeM Bid No. : GEM/2026/B/3250935
Supply, Installation, Commissioning, Operation and Maintenance of 02 nos. 140 Ton Capacity Pit-less Electronic in-Motion Railway Weighbridge as per latest RDSO specification for a period of 10 years at Haldia Dock Complex, SMPK.
Estimated Cost : ₹ 6,15,32,468.00 (including GST) | Bidding through : https://gem.gov.in
Last Date of submission: 01.12.2026 upto Time as per GeM Policy

For details including Corrigendum / Addendum (if any), please visit: https://smportkolkata.shipping.gov.in, https://eprocure.gov.in and https://gem.gov.in

Bharti Hexacom Limited
(CIN: L61100HR1995PLC132187)
Registered Office: Airtel Center, Plot No. 16, Udyog Vihar, Phase IV, Gurugram - 122015, India
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Tel.: +91 124 4222222, Fax: +91 124 4248063
Email: bharthexacom@bharti.in; **Website:** www.bharthexacom.in

INFORMATION REGARDING POSTAL BALLOT/ REMOTE E-VOTING

Members may kindly note that Bharti Hexacom Limited (the 'Company') will be seeking the consent of its members via Postal Ballot by way of remote e-voting only ('Postal Ballot' or 'e-voting') to transact the business(es) that will be set-forth in the Postal Ballot Notice ('Notice'), in compliance of the provisions of Sections 110 and 108 and all other applicable provisions, if any, of the Companies Act, 2013 read with the rules made thereunder, the applicable guidelines/ circulars issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs ('MCA Circulars'), SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 and any other applicable laws, rules and regulations.

In accordance with the applicable MCA Circulars, the Notice will be sent by email only, to the members whose e-mail addresses are registered with the Company/ Depository Participants ('DPs')/ Depository/ Registrar & Share Transfer Agent of the Company. Therefore, physical copies of the Notice, postal ballot form and pre-paid business reply envelope shall not be sent to the members for this Postal Ballot. Members shall be requested to provide their assent or dissent through remote e-voting only. The procedure to cast vote through remote e-voting and other related instructions will be provided in the Notice. The Notice will also be available on the Company's website at **https://www.bhartihexacom.in/support-shareholders-communication.html**, on the website of KFin Technologies Limited ('KFin') at **https://evoting.kfintech.com/public/Downloads.aspx** and on the websites of National Stock Exchange of India and BSE Limited at **www.nseindia.com** and **www.bseindia.com**, respectively.

Members who have not yet registered their email addresses, will not be able to receive the Notice. Such members are requested to register/ update their e-mail addresses with their respective depository participant(s) (DPs). The e-mail address registered with the DPs will be used for sending the Notice.

The Company will also be sending a physical communication to all those members whose email addresses are not registered, which shall also have the QR code to access the Notice.

In case of queries with respect to the above, members are requested to write at **einwards.ris@KFintech.com** or call at the toll free number 1800 309 4001.

This advertisement is being issued for the benefit of all the members of the Company.

For **Bharti Hexacom Limited**
Sd/-
Amit Chaturvedi
Company Secretary & Compliance Officer

Place : New Delhi
Date : November 12, 2026

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Scheme Risk-o-meter
The risk of the scheme is Very High

Source: MOAMC Internal. *Data as on: 30-Oct-2026. The information provided is for informational purposes only and should not be construed as investment advice or a recommendation to buy, sell or hold any security. Past performance may or may not be sustained in the future and is not a guarantee of future returns. Investors should consult their financial advisers before making any investment decision.

Hi-Quality and Hi-Growth represent our internal, research-based fund management strategies and do not imply guaranteed returns.

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Mutual Fund investments are subject to market risks, read all scheme related documents carefully.

Singapore Airlines backs Air India CEO's turnaround push

The turnaround, however, will take time to show results, says SIA chief Goh Choon Phong

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Air India CEO Tewolde Gebremariam is rebalancing its international network.

Singapore Airlines has backed Air India chief executive Tewolde Gebremariam's push to cut costs, improve efficiency and unlock new revenue streams, even as mounting losses and questions over fresh funding keep investor scrutiny high.

However, the turnaround will take time, Singapore Airlines (SIA) chief executive Goh Choon Phong said on Thursday, endorsing Gebremariam's strategy while tempering expectations of a quick recovery. At its analyst and media briefing, SIA outlined a series of initiatives introduced by Gebremariam, a former Ethiopian Airlines chief who took charge of Air India in October after Campbell Wilson's departure the previous month.

Gebremariam is rebalancing Air India's international network, shifting some operations from Delhi to Mumbai as a key hub for westward flights to reduce the additional fuel burden from Pakistan's airspace closure. He also seeks to increase overseas ticket sales by restoring capacity in North American and European markets, tap India's cargo market by converting passenger aircraft into freighters, and rein in costs across Air India and Air India Express by merging key teams.

Goh outlined the rationale behind the initiatives in an investor presentation, beginning with the shift in international operations to Mumbai.

Shifting some Europe- and US-bound services from Delhi to Mumbai would reduce the additional distance flown to avoid Pakistani airspace, Goh said, adding that, "The relative impact of the additional distance to be covered from Mumbai is significantly lower than Delhi. Therefore, by shifting, (it) will actually reduce, obviously, the distance covered and the fuel burned when they serve Europe in particular."

The cost of rerouting flights had previously been pegged at ₹4,000 crore a year. Goh also backed Gebremariam's efforts to increase international ticket sales, pointing to the opportunity to capture demand from overseas markets rather than relying predominantly on passengers originating in India. "For a large part of Air India's sales, it is actually coming from within India. (But) you know, for international travel, a lot of demand (is) also coming from outside India. So this is a clear opportunity that he (Gebremariam's) has identified and will be pursuing."

Cargo is a growth opportunity that Air India is yet to fully exploit, while Gebremariam has also moved to tighten cost management across two airlines. "I would say he has been very proactive and prompt in coming out with all these initiatives," Goh said.

The endorsement, however, came with a qualification. Asked whether the airline's performance in the first half had restored confidence in the investment, Goh said Gebremariam had only joined in October and that the impact of his measures was yet to be felt. "A lot of the measures that he is implementing obviously will take time to filter through," he said.

The assessment comes as SIA faces increasingly pointed questions from shareholders, analysts and Singapore's lawmakers about its exposure to Air India. At successive results briefings in the past 12 months, investors have sought clarity on the scale of Air India's loss, the prospect of further capital injections and how long SIA is prepared to wait for a turnaround.

At the July annual general meeting, shareholders pressed the company on the possibility of additional funding and circumstances under which it might reconsider the investment.

Air India remained a prominent concern at Thursday's briefing, with at least one in four questions fielded by SIA management during the investor, analyst and media session centred on Air India and its turnaround plans.

The financial numbers help explain the persistent scrutiny. SIA's share of losses from Air India stood at S$361.7 million in the six months ended September, compared with S$429.5 million a year ago, a decline of 16%. But the apparent moderation offers little evidence of an underlying financial recovery.

Asked whether Air India's losses had fallen by 16%, he was explicit: "The answer is no, because it's attributable to reversal of the provisions." SIA did not disclose the amount reversed.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

COURSE ADJUSTMENT

AIR India is shifting some international flights to Mumbai to cut fuel costs post airspace closure

THE airline plans to boost overseas ticket sales by restoring capacity in North America and Europe

IT also aims to grow cargo services by converting passenger aircraft into freighters

SIA investors remain concerned about Air India's losses, fresh funding needs and turnaround timeline

Ola Electric struggles to stem deteriorating unit economics

Ayaan Kartik
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NEW DELHI

Ola Electric's revenue fell 39% year-on-year to ₹421 crore in Q2FY27, marking its eighth consecutive quarterly fall. BLOOMBERG

Bhavish Aggarwal-led Ola Electric Mobility saw its revenue decline for the eighth consecutive quarter, while its operating profit margin, excluding depreciation and amortization, worsened year-on-year in the September quarter as the electric two-wheeler maker struggled to keep pace with rivals.

The Bengaluru-based company reported a 39% on-year decline in revenue to ₹421 crore while losses shrank to ₹362 crore from ₹418 crore a year ago in the second quarter of FY27. Its reported adjusted operating earnings before interest, tax, depreciation and amortization (Ebitda) margins worsened from -37.4% in the year-ago period to -58.5%.

The deterioration in unit economics came as rival Ather Energy Ltd reported its first-ever net profit, while Pune-based Bajaj Auto Ltd said its electric two-wheeler business was contributing double-digit positive Ebitda.

Ather recorded a profit after tax of ₹1.26 crore in the September quarter as against loss of ₹154 crore in the year-ago . Revenue surged 63% to ₹1,526 crore. Its Ebitda margin was at 4.9% as against -9.6% a year ago.

Net loss narrowed to ₹362 crore from ₹418 crore a year ago, but adjusted Ebitda margin slipped to -58.5%

Ola Electric is now banking on expanding its dealership network to 700 stores by end of March, up from 319 now and on revenue from its cell business to recover in the upcoming quarters. It expects about 20,000 wholesale orders in December, up from 3,955 in September. The firm has also closed all its stores, according to its disclosures.

It installed 6GWh capacity for its cell plant with an eye on ramping up the utilization of the plant to start booking revenue, which will largely come from its own auto business as Ola's scooters and motorcycles will use in-house cells.

"Both the businesses, the EV business and cell industry, are now seeing very strong macro pull. And we are in both," Aggarwal said during the company's earnings call on Thursday evening, expressing hope that the numbers will improve. "Business has stabilized. The balance sheet has stabilized. Operations have stabilized. And we are looking very optimistically into the next year to see really ramp up growth in a very sustainable margin accretive way," Aggarwal added.

Ola Electric has raised about ₹1,000 crore through a rights issue and ₹780 crore through a qualified institutional placement this year, which has helped the company pare down the debt on its books.

Its borrowing came down from ₹3,132 crore in December 2024 to ₹1,819 crore in September 2026, showed its data.

While the firm is looking to make a comeback with a 300-kilometre-range product from the March quarter of FY27, it is facing a challenge from rivals TVS Motor Co. Ltd, Bajaj Auto, Ather Energy and Hero MotoCorp Ltd, who have ramped up their own expansion.

The government's Vahan portal data for 2026 showed that Ola Electric has registered 122,890 units, while its closest rival in the space, Hero MotoCorp, has registered 213,372. Ather's 306,012, Bajaj's 420,857, and TVS's 492,424 unit registrations reflect the scale of the challenge for Ola Electric ahead as it tries to wrest back market share.

Its management noted on the earnings call that scooter production is ramping up as dealers place repeat orders and report market share gains in certain markets.

"Channel inventory is only about 15 days, and in many markets where our dealers opened early and have stabilized we have actually experienced market share going up well above where we were before the transition," Deepak Rastogi, chief financial officer at Ola Electric, said.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Bodhi Tree picks up a majority stake in A2B for $180 million

Priyamvada C.
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MUMBAI

A2B runs over 160 India stores and over 30 overseas.

Investment platform Bodhi Tree Systems on Thursday acquired a majority stake in the restaurant and snack shop chain Adyar Ananda Bhavan (A2B) for $180 million, providing fuel for its domestic and overseas expansion.

Veda Corporate Advisors was financial advisor to A2B while Moelis & Co. was transaction advisor to Bodhi Tree Systems. The size of the stake sold and A2B's valuation were not disclosed.

Mint was the first to report in July that Bodhi Tree Systems, backed by James Murdoch's Lupa Systems and Uday Shankar, was in talks to acquire the company at a valuation of ₹3,000-3,500 crore.

"A2B has earned the trust of millions of families through its consistent and reliable quality," said Murdoch and Shankar, who jointly founded Bodhi Tree Systems in 2021. "While A2B is a formidable brand in India, we are equally impressed by the scale and reach of its operations in Singapore, the US, Australia, Malaysia, and the UK," they added. Shankar will now serve as chairperson of A2B's new board of directors.

The transaction aims to enable A2B build a differentiated and professionally managed Indian food company. The partnership will focus on strengthening A2B's leadership and talent, building digital capability, modernizing its kitchens and manufacturing to global standards, expanding its cuisine and growing its restaurants and packaged foods across India and in international markets.

The Chennai-based company, founded as a sweet shop by brothers K.T. Srinivasa Raja and K.T. Venkatesan in the 1970s has expanded into a larger franchise over the years. It is one of South India's leading food brands for casual dining and packaged South Indian sweets and savouries. It has a strong foothold in Tamil Nadu and Karnataka and a growing presence across India, with 160 Indian over 30 overseas outlets, with over 15,000 employees.

The investment aligns with Bodhi Tree's focus on building category-leading businesses that combine strong consumer brands, disruptive technology and the ability to serve Indian consumers at scale. "We are excited to begin this next chapter with Bodhi Tree. The plan we have built will make A2B a company fit for public markets, so that our customers, employees and investors can share in its future," Srinivasa said.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Vi's Q2 performance misses estimates

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NEW DELHI

Vodafone Idea's net loss widened to ₹5,975 crore in Q2FY27. MINT

Vodafone Idea, India's third-largest telecom operator, on Thursday reported a weaker-than-expected earnings performance in the September quarter.

The Mumbai-based firm's net loss grew to ₹5,975 crore from ₹5,562 crore a year ago, missing *Bloomberg*'s estimate of ₹5,263 crore. In Q1, the firm had posted a net loss of ₹3,754 crore on higher expenses and low revenue growth.

The losses widened during the quarter owing to an exceptional loss of ₹462 crore, compared with a ₹1,816 crore gain in the previous quarter from fair-value adjustment of equity shares to be settled with promoter entity Vodafone Plc.

As of September-end, the fair market value of such earmarked shares was at ₹3,972 crore, which can be sold later, and the proceeds will come to Vodafone Idea as part of the settlement, according to the company's statement. Revenue from operations in Q2 rose 6.15% year-on-year and 1.6% quarter-on-quarter to ₹11,884 crore, also missing *Bloomberg*'s estimate of ₹11,906 crore. Subscriber additions and an increase in user spending supported its revenue growth during the quarter. Vi's quarterly Ebitda (earnings before interest, tax, depreciation and amortization) grew 6.3% year-on-year to ₹4,981 crore.

Vodafone Idea said more than ₹4,000 crore of incremental bank funding was arranged in the second quarter

"Our Q2FY27 performance reflects steady progress against our priorities. We are encouraged by the continued improvement in our net subscriber additions, supported by our network expansion and enhanced customer experience," said Abhijit Kishore, chief executive of Vodafone Idea, in a statement.

"We have placed capex orders of over ₹13,200 crore, of which around ₹6,000 crore capex was executed. Encouraged by progress in discussions to raise funding, we are confident to place more orders and sustain the momentum in our network expansion."

In its statement, the company said it secured total funding of over ₹10,500 crore through the first half of the current fiscal year, including warrants and fund- and non-fund-based facilities. It said more than ₹4,000 crore of incremental bank funding was arranged in Q2.

The telecom operator declared the results after market hours. On Thursday, its shares closed 0.7% higher at ₹12.97 on the National Stock Exchange, while the Nifty 50 ended 0.2% higher.

Its weak earnings come as rivals Reliance Jio and Bharti Airtel report strong performances. Jio leads the subscriber market with 542.4 million users, followed by Airtel India with 498.7 million.

Vodafone Idea is also looking to tie up a bank debt of ₹35,000 crore. The timeline of the debt fundraise is crucial, given its ₹45,000-crore network expansion plan and its yearly spectrum repayments over the next few years.

During the quarter, Vodafone Idea net added 1.3 million subscribers, taking its base to 194.4 million. However, on a year-on-year basis, the subscriber base fell by 2.3 million from 196.7 million.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Benecore invests ₹200 cr in the hygiene value chain

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A key input material for India's diaper and sanitary napkin industry, largely imported until now, is set to get a domestic source as German-Indian joint venture Benecore invests over ₹200 crore in a Bhopal plant.

The firm expects the first phase of the plant to generate about ₹300 crore in revenue. It plans to double the capacity by 2029, taking its revenue to about ₹600 crore, said Rudra Chatterjee, chairman of Benecore and the Obeetee Group. The product, known as non-woven fabric, is a thin sheet made by bonding fibres rather than weaving them. Used in hygiene products, it absorbs and distribute liquid, making diapers and sanitary napkins more effective. Its softness is key, as the material comes into direct contact with the skin.

Much of the material used by Indian diaper and sanitary napkin makers is imported, mainly from China. While cheaper, locally made alternatives are available, they do not offer the same liquid-holding capacity, he added. "What's interesting is that we are making this product domestically," Chatterjee said.

Benecore, formerly TWE OBT, was launched in 2023, when Germany's TWE Group GmbH formed a 50:50 JV with Obeetee Textiles. Obeetee, Chatterjee's other business, was founded in 1920 in Mirzapur, Uttar Pradesh, and is one of India's oldest manufacturers and exporters of handmade carpets and rugs. The firm specializes in luxury hand-knotted, hand-tufted and flat-woven carpets.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

When geopolitics rewrites the script, can filmmakers retain the plot?

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NEW DELHI

Salman Khan's *Maatrubhumi: May War Rest in Peace*, based on a India-China conflict, was delayed amid improving bilateral ties.

Salman Khan's latest film, *Maatrubhumi: May War Rest in Peace*, based on the 2020 India-China conflict, was delayed for several months as relations between the two countries improved. An altered version has been cleared for theatrical release on 4 December.

As successes such as *Padmaavat* and *Udta Punjab* show, substantial changes to a film's script or treatment need not hurt box-office prospects. But the episode highlights a wider industry challenge: big-budget films can take two to three years to reach screens, during which geopolitical realities can change dramatically. A story conceived in one context may be released in another.

To manage this uncertainty, studios must go beyond standard force majeure clauses and build geopolitical risk assessments and "script agility" provisions into co-production contracts. They should also negotiate alternative distribution options, including digital releases with jurisdiction-specific geo-blocking, to keep films commercially viable if diplomatic hurdles delay theatrical clearance.

"A film's development, production and release can span years, during which diplomatic relations, elections, conflicts, public sentiment and regulatory expectations may change. This creates both creative and financial risk," said Alay Razvi, managing partner at law firm Accord Juris.

Studios can manage these risks through early legal and sensitivity reviews, expert consultation, flexible scripting, contingency budgets, staged financing, insurance where available and alternative release plans, Razvi added. They should avoid making a film dependent on a temporary political mood and preserve the flexibility for proportionate reshoots, revised marketing or postponement. Early engagement with regulators may also reduce avoidable delays.

Films dealing with geopolitics, religion or sensitive historical events are particularly exposed to external intervention, agreed Rahul Hingmire, managing partner, Vis Legis Law Practice. Certification requirements, diplomatic concerns or restrictions on market access can sometimes necessitate changes even after production.

UNDER PRESSURE

BIG films can take 2-3 years to reach the screens, exposing them to geopolitical and regulatory shifts

STUDIOS must build geopolitical risk assessments and flexible clauses into contracts for scripts

For instance, *Red Dawn* reportedly changed its Chinese invading force to North Korea, while *Padmaavat* underwent title and content modifications amid political controversy. Such changes may protect a film's release prospects, but they can weaken character motivation or narrative consistency. Once alterations affect the core premise, the creative and commercial risks increase considerably, Hingmire said.

"I have seen titles change, scenes disappear and entire storylines get rewritten weeks before release. As exhibitors, we feel these changes first. When a film is in flux, we hold back on show planning, in-cinema promotions and advance bookings, and the uncertainty shows up in the opening," said Deepak Adwani, executive director, Miraj Entertainment Ltd.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

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NOTICE TO EQUITY SHAREHOLDERS
TRANSFER OF EQUITY SHARES TO THE INVESTOR EDUCATION AND PROTECTION FUND

This Notice is published pursuant to the provisions of Section 124(6) of the Companies Act, 2013 ("Act") read with the Investor Education and Protection Fund ("IEPF") Authority (Accounting, Audit, Transfer and Refund) Rules, 2016 ("Rules"). The said Section and the Rules, amongst other matters, contain provisions for transfer of shares in respect of which dividend remains unpaid or unclaimed for a period of seven consecutive years to the DEMAT Account of the IEPF Authority (the "IEPF DEMAT Account").

The 4th Interim Dividend (2019-2020) ("dividend") declared on the shares, as per details available on the Company's website https://www.hcltech.com/investors/iepf-details, is lying unpaid or unclaimed since February 17, 2020. Accordingly, in compliance with the Rules, these shares are due for transfer to the IEPF Authority on February 17, 2027. Individual notices are being sent by the Company to all the concerned shareholders to provide them with an opportunity to claim their respective unpaid dividends. In case the valid claims are not received from the concerned shareholders on or before February 16, 2027, necessary steps will be initiated by the Company to transfer the shares held by the concerned shareholders to the IEPF Demat Account without any further notice in the following manner:

a) In case the shares are held in Physical form –The original share certificate(s) which stands registered in the name of the shareholder(s) will be deemed to be cancelled and in lieu thereof, corresponding share(s) will be issued and transferred in favour of the IEPF.

b) In case the shares are held in Demat form- The Company shall transfer the shares by way of corporate action through the respective depositories (NSDL or CDSL) to the IEPF.

Please note that no claims shall lie against the Company in respect of unclaimed dividends and shares transferred to the IEPF pursuant to the Rules. However, it may be noted that the concerned shareholder(s) can claim the shares and dividends from the IEPF Authority by submitting an online application in the prescribed Form IEPF-5, available on the website www.iepf.gov.in and sending a physical copy of the same to the Nodal Officer of the Company along with the requisite documents enumerated in Form IEPF-5.

In case of any clarifications/queries in this regard, shareholder(s) are requested to contact the Company's Registrar & Share Transfer Agent, M/s. MUFG Intime India Private Limited, Unit- HCL Technologies Limited, C-101, Embassy 247, L.B.S. Marg, Vikhroli (West), Mumbai, Maharashtra-400083, Telephone: 8108116767 E-mail: Investor.helpdesk@in.mpms.mufg.com.

For HCL Technologies Limited

Date: November 12, 2026
Place: Noida (U.P.)

Manish Anand
Company Secretary

CNH CAPITAL

CNH Industrial Capital (India) Private Limited
(CIN: U65999DL2017PTC325228)
Regd Office: 4th Floor Rectangle No.1 Behind Marriot Hotel,
Commercial Complex D4, Saket, New Delhi South Delhi DL 110017

Statement under Regulation 52(4) of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 for the quarter and half year ended 30 September 2026 (Rs. in Millions)

Extract of Unaudited Financial Results for the Quarter and Half Year ended 30 September 2026

S.No.	Particulars	Quarter Ended			Half Year ended		Year ended
		30.09.2026 (Unaudited)	30.06.2026 (Unaudited)	30.09.2025 (Unaudited)	30.09.2026 (Unaudited)	30.09.2025 (Unaudited)	31.03.2026 (Audited)
1.	Total Income from Operations	767.29	767.92	660.21	1,535.21	1,316.96	2,798.97
2.	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period (before tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	104.89	171.33	87.07	276.22	268.05	662.54
3.	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	104.89	171.33	87.07	276.22	268.05	653.37
4.	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	100.28	106.69	75.42	206.96	205.22	484.13
5.	Total Comprehensive Income for the period (comprising Profit / (Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax))	126.12	98.85	72.94	224.96	190.18	500.46
6.	Paid up Equity Share Capital	3,972.00	3,972.00	3,972.00	3,972.00	3,972.00	3,972.00
7.	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve)	2,280.51	2,154.61	1,738.71	2,280.51	1,738.71	2,053.64
8.	Securities Premium Account	-	-	-	-	-	-
9.	Net Worth	6,252.51	6,126.61	5,710.71	6,252.51	5,710.71	6,025.64
10.	Paid up Debt Capital / Outstanding Debt	18,810.37	15,027.99	16,342.65	18,810.37	16,342.65	18,033.83
11.	Outstanding Redeemable Preference Shares	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA
12.	Debt Equity Ratio	3.01	2.45	2.86	3.01	2.86	2.99
13.	Earnings Per Share (of Rs. 10/- each) (for continuing and discontinued operations)*						
	a) Basic	0.25	0.27	0.19	0.52	0.52	1.22
	b) Diluted	0.25	0.27	0.19	0.52	0.52	1.22
14.	Capital Redemption Reserve	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA
15.	Debenture Redemption Reserve	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA
16.	Debt Service Coverage Ratio	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA
17.	Interest Service Coverage Ratio	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA

*Quarter and half year end Basic EPS and Diluted EPS are not annualised

Note 1: The above unaudited financial results for the quarter and half year ended 30 September 2026 have been reviewed by the Audit Committee and subsequently approved by the Board of Directors at their respective meetings held on 12 November 2026 and are limited reviewed by the Statutory Auditors of the Company pursuant to the requirement of Regulation 52 of the Securities Exchange Board of India ("SEBI") (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements), 2015 (as amended) including relevant circulars issued by the SEBI from time to time.

Note 2: The above is an extract of the detailed format of the quarter and half year ended results filed with the Bombay Stock Exchange ("BSE") under Regulation 52 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements), 2015. The full financial results are available on the website of BSE (https://listing.bseindia.com).

Note 3: For other items referred to in the sub-clauses of the Regulation 52 (4) of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements), Regulations, 2015 the pertinent disclosures have been made to the BSE and can be assessed on (https://listing.bseindia.com).

Note 4: The results have been prepared in accordance with the recognition and measurement principles laid down in Indian Accounting Standard (Ind AS) 34 - "Interim Financial Reporting" as prescribed under section 133 of the Companies Act,2013 (the Act) and other accounting principles generally accepted in India.

For CNH Industrial Capital (India) Private Limited
Sd/-
Pankaj Gupta
Managing Director
DIN No.: 10432477

Place: Gurugram
Date: 12 November 2026

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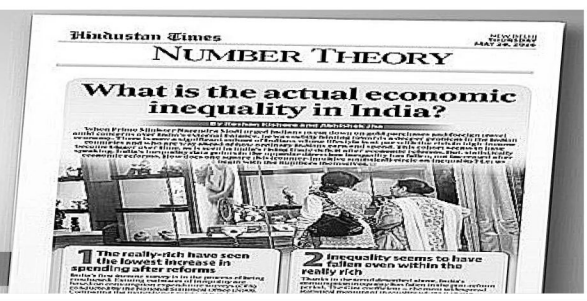

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Huang ousted by Nvidia as CEO

Jensen Huang's departure follows reports of two affairs; finance chief Colette Kress, who joined Nvidia 13 years ago, named interim CEO

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

Nvidia Corp. chief executive officer (CEO) Jensen Huang, the preeminent face of the artificial intelligence (AI) infrastructure boom, was ousted from his post after reports of two affairs, including one with a woman suspected of spying for China.

Longtime chief financial officer (CFO) Colette Kress is taking the job of interim CEO, Nvidia said on Thursday, and Huang will no longer have ties with the chipmaker. The board, which has never had a chair before, appointed director Harvey Jones to that role. Jones, 73, formerly led Synopsys Inc., a company that Nvidia took a $2 billion stake in last year.

The resignation deepens a crisis partly of Nvidia's own making, since the company has long lacked a clear succession plan. The 63-year-old has been Nvidia's only CEO during its three-decade history. He carefully managed every part of the business, while also serving as a champion for the broader AI industry.

Huang transformed the business from a niche maker of computer graphics components into the world's biggest seller of AI computing chips, the highly prized products at the centre of a global spending frenzy.

"Jensen Huang's resignation is a watershed moment for Nvidia, which now has to prove it can maintain its AI dominance without the leader largely responsible for building it," Emarketer senior analyst Asa Hiken said in a note. "And given the broader AI industry's heavy dependence on Nvidia's chips, Huang's departure introduces uncertainty well beyond the company itself."

Nvidia shares initially plunged as much as 14% before paring their losses. The stock was down 7.5% to $160.67 as of 10.08am in New York, erasing more than $300 billion from the company's valuation.

"Jensen's contributions to Nvidia are profound," the board said. "Nvidia is one of the most consequential technology companies in the world. The board and the company thank Jensen for his immeasurable contributions to the company and the industry."

Huang, one of the three engineers who founded the chipmaker in 1993, had been under intense pressure since Sunday, when he admitted to a romantic relationship with Alice Huang, a former executive at the Singapore-based data centre firm Megaspeed International.

The Nvidia turmoil is rippling through the entire AI complex on Thursday, dragging down shares of semiconductor companies such as Micron Technology Inc. and Marvell Technology Inc., the so-called neoclouds such as CoreWeave Inc. and Nebius Group NV, and even weighing on AI-adjacent companies, including power equipment firms Vertiv Holdings Co. and Bloom Energy Corp. On the other hand, shares of Nvidia rivals such as Advanced Micro Devices Inc. and Broadcom Inc. gained.

Jensen Huang (left) and Colette Kress. AP & REUTERS

"There will be a tremendous loss of credibility for Nvidia overall," Bloomberg Intelligence analyst Mandeep Singh said in a Bloomberg Television interview. "Given their importance in the AI ecosystem and everything that they were doing from a deal perspective," Singh said Huang's exit may have a disproportionate impact on the neoclouds supplying AI computing and open-source and open-weight AI model developers.

Kress, who joined Nvidia 13 years ago after stints at Microsoft Corp. and Cisco Systems Inc., has spent her career in financial roles. While she has represented the company at Wall Street-related events, her public role has been confined to Nvidia's numbers and the majority of the communication with the financial community has been handled by her former boss.

Under Huang's leadership, Nvidia's shares had soared more than 700,000% since it became a public company in 1999. The firm's market valuation has at times topped $5 trillion, ranking it among the largest companies in the world. The staggering growth eclipses anything accomplished by Apple Inc.'s Steve Jobs, Microsoft Corp.'s Bill Gates or Amazon.com Inc.'s Jeff Bezos.

Huang's departure threatens to reverberate far beyond Nvidia. He has used Nvidia's financial strength to back dozens of major AI players including frontier labs OpenAI and Anthropic PBC. He's also both invested in and backstopped financing deals for cloud computing firms including CoreWeave Inc., inspiring others to forge similar arrangements with one another to bolster the entire AI ecosystem. Big names on Wall Street including Michael Burry of 'The Big Short' fame have warned that such circular deals are artificially inflating AI demand.

"As a student of economic history, I don't know if there's ever been such a key man holding so much of this industry up," Blue Bear Capital investor Thomas Ferguson said of Huang while speaking at the BNEF Houston Summit on Wednesday ahead of his departure.

Under Huang, Nvidia's shares had soared more than 700,000% since it became a public company in 1999

Huang has also led high-profile efforts to promote the worldwide expansion of data centres, travelling extensively to speak at conferences, lectures and other events. Wearing his signature leather jackets, he's drawn crowds of fans swept up in "Jensanity."

The executive has become close with US President Donald Trump, appearing at White House meetings on technology, at state dinners and aboard Air Force One. Huang has enjoyed far greater access to the president than most corporate leaders. Trump on Monday backed Huang as "a very honorable man."

The revelations about the Nvidia CEO's affair with Alice Huang, an executive at Megaspeed, raised serious questions about his judgment. Huang also had a relationship with Kimberly Powell, Nvidia's vice president of healthcare.

Megaspeed, which was spun out of a Chinese gaming enterprise, is one of Nvidia's largest Southeast Asian customers and has been under US investigation for months related to the potential smuggling of Nvidia's advanced AI chips into China, *Bloomberg* has reported. Megaspeed and Nvidia have denied wrongdoing.

Using a network of companies, Alice Huang also forged ties with DeepSeek, a top Chinese AI startup, *The Information* reported on Thursday. She invested in the business with the intention of supplying it with advanced Nvidia chips, the news outlet said.

Nvidia's board has been working with an outside firm to identify potential replacements for Huang, a person familiar with the matter said on Wednesday, asking not to be identified because the information isn't public. Directors had met remotely on Wednesday to discuss Huang's fate, people familiar with the situation said.

The mystery businessman who introduced Huang to his paramour

Lingling Wei
feedback@livemint.com

Before the affair that now threatens his job as Nvidia's chief executive, Jensen Huang was introduced to his future romantic interest, Alice Huang, by a Chinese businessman he'd known for a decade, Kang Wei.

Kang also happened to be Alice Huang's husband, said people who know the couple.

For two years, Kang appeared to accept his wife's romantic relationship with the Nvidia CEO and spoke openly of their closeness, these people said. Sometimes, Kang told associates, half-jokingly, that she was a personal assistant to Jensen Huang, they said.

The introduction to the CEO at the center of the global AI boom is the clearest example of how Kang and Alice Huang leveraged personal connections to further an array of business ventures in China, Singapore, Taiwan and elsewhere.

Over the past decade, Kang and Alice Huang hopscotched from one lucrative opportunity to the next—videogame companies, pharmaceutical takeovers and cloud computing—each time weaving a web of related entities, transferring stakes among themselves and capitalizing on whatever connections were at hand, said people familiar with the couple's business dealings. Nvidia's AI chips were the latest play for a couple with a track record of riding hot trades and, on occasion, running afoul of regulators.

Now the couple are the subject of a raft of investigations, and the blast radius of their relations with Jensen Huang is expanding.

U.S. officials believe that China's intelligence services recruited Alice Huang as an asset because of her access to the chip-designer chief. Nvidia's board is now preparing to oust Jensen Huang as CEO, after another alleged affair came to light on Wednesday.

Jensen Huang acknowledged in a letter to staff Sunday that he had been unfaithful to his wife and apologized for violating his family's and his employees' trust.

The U.S. and Singapore are scrutinizing Megaspeed, a Singapore-based cloud-service provider, over allegations that the company potentially transshipped billions of dollars in export-restricted Nvidia artificial-intelligence chips to China.

Alice Huang met Jensen Huang many times in 2024, 2025. AFP

Megaspeed sent some Nvidia chips to China despite U.S. laws barring such exports, said people familiar with the matter.

Taiwanese authorities said they had revoked Alice Huang's entry permit and barred her from returning to the island where she met Nvidia's chief several times. Taiwanese officials said they are now investigating whether her visits involved intelligence gathering or violated the island's anti-infiltration act.

Alice Huang was detained by Singapore authorities in the summer of 2025 and prevented from leaving the country, said people told of her detention. The exit ban was later lifted and she was in China earlier this year , they said.

The government of Singapore has said it continues to investigate Megaspeed but hasn't investigated Alice Huang's ties to China. It didn't respond to questions about her detention.

Kang, who had been detained in Shanghai earlier this year on inquiries regarding stock-market manipulation involving listed companies, was recently released and shared a photo of himself at Stanford University with friends, said the people who know the couple.

Attempts to reach Kang and Alice Huang were unsuccessful. Nvidia declined to comment.

Beijing denied reports that there was a Chinese plot to spy on Jensen Huang. Ministry of Foreign Affairs spokesman Guo Jiakun said early this week, "The narrative about so-called Chinese spies is entirely based on groundless speculation—it is nothing more than slander and smearing."

'Harmonious prosperity'

Kang, who is in his early 50s, had been a star fund manager in China before setting out on his own, founding a company called Shanghai Hexi in 2010. Alice Huang, now in her late 40s, pursued a master's degree in media management from Hong Kong Baptist University in the late 2000s, said a graduate in the same program.

Though it couldn't be determined when the couple met, Shanghai Hexi, a name meaning "harmonious prosperity," became core to their business-fueled relationship. They started co-running the firm in 2016, according to corporate-registry records.

Shanghai Hexi invested in a range of tech businesses including videogames, which created an opportunity for Kang in the 2010s to meet Jensen Huang, then a rising CEO from Silicon Valley. At the time, Nvidia focused on chips for videogames, and Jensen met Kang in Asia, said a person who worked at one of Kang's portfolio of companies and said he helped connect the two men.

In 2018, China's securities regulator fined Kang and the couple's company for failing to disclose its holdings in a Chinese pharmaceutical company and other violations in a takeover battle. Kang and Shanghai Hexi contested the regulator's findings during official hearings, but the regulator rejected their argument.

By the early 2020s, Kang and Alice Huang were gravitating toward the business of cloud computing—providing remote computing power to corporate clients. Through a company in which a fund they ran owned a partial stake, they began to build relationships with some Chinese tech giants.

In 2023, the couple found a new opportunity to draw upon their connections: AI data centers. They acquired the Singapore unit of a videogame company in which they had previously invested, said corporate-registry records and people familiar with the matter.

This unit was renamed Megaspeed International in March 2023, and Alice Huang was registered as a director. Kang worked with her in building the business, the people said.

A key player in getting Megaspeed off the ground was Alibaba , the Chinese e-commerce leader that has also been an aggressive player in AI, said people familiar with the negotiations at the time. The U.S. had begun imposing export controls on advanced chips in late 2022, preventing Nvidia from selling them directly to China over concerns they could boost China's military and surveillance capabilities.

Alibaba was looking for a partner that could help it access computing power from data centers stuffed with Nvidia chips located outside China, the people said.

An Nvidia partner

Megaspeed told Nvidia that Alibaba would be an anchor customer, a big enough client to help earn Kang and Alice Huang's company priority access to chips as an "Nvidia cloud partner" in November 2023, those people said. Shortly after, Alice Huang told an associate that she had gotten in touch with Jensen Huang and Megaspeed would soon start business smoothly.

Megaspeed brought many of the Nvidia servers it acquired to data centers in Malaysia and provided computing power to Alibaba, people familiar with the matter said.

But that wasn't all. It shipped some of them to China including to a Shanghai cloud-computing provider called Century Litong, owned by a Shanghai-listed company with which Kang had done business, the people said.

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

Then as now, the U.S. bans the export of advanced Nvidia AI chips to China. The Information earlier reported the connection between Megaspeed and Century Litong.

Megaspeed has said it operates "fully within the bounds of all applicable export control regulations" and upholds the highest standards of legal conduct.

Litong didn't respond to a request for comment.

The couple expanded their business. Investors approached by Alice Huang and Kang in Shanghai and Singapore said the couple pitched several data-center projects between late 2024 and June 2025 including two in Southeast Asia and one in Shanghai. According to the potential investors, the duo said that investors could expect to triple their money in three years and expressed confidence they had ways to bring Nvidia chips into China.

Alice Huang met Jensen Huang many times in 2024 and 2025, according to photos and people who met the two. Local media in Taiwan captured Jensen Huang's daughter cheerfully taking photos of the two at a dinner in May 2025.

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The 31-year-old trader who called out Huang's 'China problem', shorted Nvidia

Ben Cohen
feedback@livemint.com

When Christian Lamarco decided to start his own short-selling firm, he named it in honor of the spies who gathered intelligence for George Washington during the Revolutionary War.

He had watched a television show about the Culper ring, which secretly tracked the movements of British forces almost 250 years ago, and he couldn't help but see the similarities between his shorting and their spycraft.

Now he's caught up in his own story involving national security, the president of the United States and spectacular allegations of modern espionage.

Six months ago, Culper Research published a report outlining its case against Nvidia , which had become the most valuable company in the world by making the chips that power the global AI economy.

His investigation raised questions about Nvidia's business in China and what he called an "uncomfortably close" relationship between CEO Jensen Huang and a woman named Alice Huang, who was an executive at one of the company's major business partners in Southeast Asia. The 40-page report summarized the firm's short position in a simple thesis.

"This is not a bet against AI," Culper wrote. "We are short Nvidia for one reason: the company has a significant China problem."

At first, nobody paid much attention to the 31-year-old short seller whose research typically focused on companies most people have never heard of. The day his report about one of the most important companies on the planet was published, Jensen Huang touched down in Beijing aboard Air Force One on a state trip with President Trump. The next day, Nvidia's stock hit a record high.

"Sometimes, people care about what you have to say. Sometimes, they don't," Lamarco said in an interview. "I guess in this case, they cared six months later."

Six months later, questions about Alice Huang, her coziness with Jensen Huang and the significance of Nvidia's China problem are no longer confined to a short seller's research.

Nvidia has lost more than $1 trillion in market value and its stock is down 20% since Culper Research's report. AFP

This week, those questions turned into revelations that Nvidia's CEO was having an extramarital affair with a woman who is now suspected of working for Chinese intelligence services. Culper's report went from being ignored to becoming the rare piece of securities analysis to go viral.

"I've never quite had anything like this," he said.

As his research blew up, so did his phone. He muted notifications from X, where his Nvidia posts have racked up millions of views, and turned down TV interview requests.

Nvidia has lost more than $1 trillion in market value and its stock is down 20% since Culper's report, but it's unclear if the epic corporate fiasco has made Lamarco money. He declined to say how much he's earned from the most prescient call of his career—or if he's still shorting the company.

Lamarco grew up in upstate New York and discovered the world of investing as a finance major at Grove City College, a small Christian school in Pennsylvania. One day, Lamarco drove to Carnegie Mellon for a stock-picking contest where he would compete with Ivy Leaguers. His goal, he said at the time, was to "prove that Grove City students can compete with students from the best schools in the country." Lamarco and his teammate went long on Nexstar Media Group and won second place—and a $100 prize.

Since finance recruiters weren't in the habit of visiting Grove City College, Lamarco knew he would have to be creative and aggressive to get their attention. He emailed his own research to hedge funds and got a job at a long-short firm in Chicago, where he worked from 2017 to 2019. Then he moved to Pittsburgh with a few months of savings and struck out on his own.

When his firm needed a name, he remembered "Turn: Washington's Spies," an AMC show that he first watched in a high-school friend's basement. He thought the Culper ring's work monitoring British troops in occupied New York had something in common with his own.

"Similarly," he wrote, "we take an exhaustive, investigative approach to investment research."

At first, nobody paid much attention to the short seller whose research focused on firms most haven't heard of

Before long, he moved to New York himself and began working out of a Brooklyn apartment while his Shiba Inu begged for treats.

Like other short sellers, the sleuths at Culper say they are out to expose deception, financial irregularities and all the ways companies scam investors—and, of course, make a profit.

Since its founding, Culper has targeted dozens of public companies, mostly small-cap stocks. But Lamarco and his two analysts have taken on powerful forces before.

Last year, a window and glass manufacturer hired Elon Musk's attorney and sued Lamarco for defamation after he alleged the company had links to the Sinaloa drug cartel.

He also tried to make a $1 million wager with Jimmy Fallon, offering in his report to pay up if the late-night host flew in electric air taxis made by Archer Aviation , a company whose CEO appeared on "The Tonight Show"—and a company that Culper was betting against. He never heard back.

His report on Nvidia was months in the making. Intrigued by reporting in *The New York Times* and *Bloomberg News* last year, Lamarco started digging with his team of two analysts. Then they stopped, setting the research aside because it didn't seem worth their time.

"It's just highly unlikely that you're going to find something that everyone else has missed," he said. "Are we really going to have anything to say about the largest company in the world?"

As it turned out, they would. In March, when federal prosecutors charged Super Micro Computer officials with smuggling Nvidia chips into China in violation of U.S. export controls, Lamarco decided it was time to pick up the investigation again. "Let's dig a little bit deeper," he said.

They used a network of paid experts to interview former Nvidia employees, who speculated about a "special relationship" between Jensen Huang and Alice Huang. They analyzed scrubbed code and Singaporean and Malaysian corporate filings. They even pored over YouTube footage from outside a Taiwanese noodle shop.

By May, it was time to reveal what they found.

After a sleepless night, a bagel and a morning cigarette, he hit publish. In that moment, he was confident in the research. What the market did with that research, though, there was no way of knowing.

"When it's some $500 million pump-and-dump, you can have a sense of what might happen next," he said. "I just have no idea here."

At first, not much happened at all. The stock went down, up, down and up again. Last month, Nvidia was worth more than ever.

This month, as the company fell into crisis, the firm named after a spy ring was gathering intelligence on its next target.

"There's something relatively big," Lamarco said. "But by its very nature, nothing will be as big as this."

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NEWS IN NUMBERS

16%
RISE IN second-quarter profit that was reported by state-run aerospace and defence firm Hindustan Aeronautics on Thursday, aided by robust orders.

₹834 cr
THE VALUE of orders HFCL secured to supply optical fibre cables to an international customer, scheduled for completion by June 2027.

$1 bn
THE ESTIMATED pre-order revenue for GTA 6, ahead of its 19 November launch, setting records with over 10 million pre-orders, per Sensor Tower.

1.5 mn
THE PROJECTED annual US humanoid robot production by 2035, according to J.P. Morgan, driven by labour shortages, and improving economics.

5
THE PROPOSED number of vehicles legally required in a fleet to enter the self-drive and chauffeur-driven car rental business, down from 50 currently.

HOWINDIALIVES.COM

India's TB deaths fall 38% since 2015

India has recorded a 38% reduction in tuberculosis (TB) mortality since 2015, outperforming the global decline of 35%, the Union health ministry said on Thursday. Highlighted in the World Health Organization's (WHO's) *Global Tuberculosis Report 2026* released on Thursday, the findings showed India saw a 94% treatment success rate in drug-susceptible TB patients.

According to the WHO report, India's estimated TB mortality rate dropped from 280 per million people in 2015 to 180 per million in 2025. Meanwhile, a nationally representative TB prevalence survey conducted in 2025 by the Indian Council of Medical Research—National Institute for Research in Tuberculosis (ICMR-NIRT) has been shared with WHO. The findings are currently under technical review, after which the WHO will publish an updated country profile for India. **PRIYANKA SHARMA**

Shuja Siddiqui named CEO of Avendus Finance

Financial services group Avendus has named Shuja Siddiqui as chief executive officer of Avendus Finance Pvt. Ltd as it looks to build a specialized loan against securities-led Non-Banking Financial Company (NBFC), offering tailored lending solutions for its private banking clients.

Siddiqui brings over 24 years of experience across wealth management, credit and capital markets, having been part of the founding teams of wealth businesses at two institutions, Avendus said in a statement. He was previously managing director and senior adviser at Julius Baer Capital. The appointment comes as Avendus strengthens its overall credit franchise, with Nilesh Dhedhi taking on the mandate to scale its private credit platform, including the debt syndication vertical. **STAFF WRITER**

Costco eyes India tech footprint as AI bets grow

US retailer Costco sees room to expand its technology presence in India beyond Hyderabad as it accelerates international growth, with its first global capability centre playing a key role in artificial intelligence and cybersecurity, a top executive said.

The Hyderabad centre, which employs more than 70 people, supports global operations and is expected to grow to several hundred staff over the next five to six years, Javier Polit, Costco's chief information and digital officer, told *Reuters* on Thursday.

"We're going to grow our business internationally at a greater velocity than we have been in the past. So there'll be more presence in this geography for sure," Polit said. Artificial intelligence (AI) has delivered productivity gains of up to 60% in some projects, Polit said, prompting to build more tools for global use, including a Hyderabad-developed geofencing tool that identifies customers approaching stores to speed check-in and checkout. **REUTERS**

P&G Hygiene posts 7% drop in profit

Procter & Gamble (P&G) Hygiene and Health Care reported a 7% decline in quarterly profit on Thursday as the Indian consumer goods maker battled raw material and energy cost inflation brought on by the Middle East crisis.

The fallout from the conflict has driven up energy and freight costs, raised commodity prices and strained supply chains, with corporates globally jacking up prices to counter the margin squeeze.

For P&G hygiene and health care, a subsidiary of American consumer goods group Procter & Gamble, profit dropped to ₹196 crore ($20.93 million) for the second quarter ended 30 September, from ₹210 crore, a year earlier.

Shares in the Indian maker of Vicks lozenges and Whisper sanitary pads fell nearly 4% after results. They were last down 1.4% at ₹7,099.50. Revenue from operations slipped marginally to ₹1,145 crore. **REUTERS**

RBI may bar PE firms from controlling multiple NBFCs

Central bank seeks to curb contagion risks while easing smaller PE investments

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REUTERS

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) is working on proposals that would prevent private equity firms from holding a controlling stake in more than one non-bank lender or non-banking financial company (NBFC), two people with knowledge of the plans said.

It is concerned that financial stress at a global private equity firm or its affiliates could have a contagion effect across several non-bank lenders in which it has significant investments, they said.

Authorities, however, hope to encourage smaller financial investments that will be subject to lesser scrutiny, the people added, declining to be identified as the discussions are private.

Under Indian law, control is defined as a large stake—25% in the case of listed firms—though ownership can be smaller and still be considered a controlling stake if the investor has the right to appoint a majority of the directors or can control a firm's management or policy decisions. Holdings of 15% or less will be considered a financial investment and attract less scrutiny, according to one of the people. A draft of the rules will be finalised after public consultation and they could be formally issued early next year, the person said.

The RBI has at times moved to prevent controlling investments in multiple non-bank lenders. US private equity firm Bain Capital's purchase of 41.7% of Manappuram Finance last year was approved on condition that it divest its 93% ownership in another non-bank lender Tyger Capital, formerly Adani Capital.

The principle has also applied to non-private equity firms.

The Indian Venture and Alternate Capital Association has lobbied RBI, seeking permission for different entities within a group to acquire stakes of more than 20% in multiple non-banking financial companies.

Siddarth M Pai, co-chair of the association's regulatory affairs committee and founder of venture capital firm 3one4 Capital, said that many private equity firms and venture capital funds want to include fintech and financial services across their various funds, but face issues due to ownership thresholds.

India's weight in MSCI emerging market index had dropped to nearly 11% by May 2026. BLOOMBERG

MSCI adds 4 Indian firms to int'l index

Index provider Morgan Stanley Capital International (MSCI) has added four Indian companies to its flagship Global Standard index and increased the weights of 11 other stocks as part of its November index review, effectively increasing India's weight in the MSCI Emerging Markets Index.

MSCI review changes dated 11 November showed that Adani Green Energy, IT company Coforge, Life Insurance Corp. of India and e-commerce company Meesho were added to the flagship index.

Their shares rose between 0.5% and 3.4% after the announcement.

The review also removed agro-chemicals maker PI Industries.

"India's weight in the standard emerging market index will move up to 13.15% from 12.9% after this review implementation," India Infoline Limited said in a note.

India's weight in MSCI emerging market index had dropped to nearly 11% by May 2026, from the peak of 20% in 2024, as AI-driven rallies in Taiwan and South Korea outpaced Indian equities, which lacked large AI-linked technology stocks. **REUTERS**

ReNew announced fresh investments on clean energy manufacturing. BLOOMBERG

ReNew, CleanMax bet ₹1.3 tn on AP

Green-power majors ReNew Energy Global Plc and Clean Max Enviro Energy Solutions Ltd on Thursday announced investments of around ₹80,000 crore and ₹50,000 crore, respectively, in setting up data centres, solar component manufacturing capacity, and renewable energy expansion in Andhra Pradesh.

Nasdaq-listed ReNew announced fresh investments spanning digital infrastructure and clean energy manufacturing. The investments include an ₹67,000 crore for a 1 Gigawatt (GW) green hyperscale data centre in Anakapalli, ₹11,000 crore for polysilicon and metallurgical silicon manufacturing facilities in Anakapalli and Nellore, and ₹1,500 crore for a permanent-magnet manufacturing facility in Rambilli. The announcements were made at the CII Partnership Summit 2026 in Visakhapatnam. ReNew added that the permanent-magnet manufacturing facility in Rambilli is expected to be commissioned by March 2029. The company will also establish the ReNew centre for technical excellence in Visakhapatnam. **REUTERS**

Power shortages push discoms to costly bilateral deals

FROM PAGE 1

The scramble shows how supply constraints are reshaping India's short-term power market, with discoms willing to pay a premium to secure electricity and avoid shortages during peak demand.

Peak electricity demand recently hit a record 270.8 gigawatts (GW), while daily power deficits crossed 30 million units in September, pushing the monthly shortfall to a three-year high of 560 million units.

The short-term market, which accounts for about 15% of the country's electricity supply, is dominated by power exchanges and bilateral trade, which account for 46% and 41% of the market, respectively. The remainder is managed through real-time grid deviations and balancing mechanisms.

"The high shortages this year led discoms to prefer short term trade agreements for 15 days or 30 days," said an official with a distribution company on condition of anonymity. "When there is high demand and low supply, and you are not sure of the supplies, then one goes for such arrangements. You would try to be on the safer side on the face of such shortages. Also, the prices made it attractive for developers to sell it through bilateral trade, rather than on exchanges."

Peak electricity demand recently hit a record 270.8GW, while daily power deficits crossed 30 million units in September. REUTERS

Discoms also need to avoid failing to meet scheduled power supplies, which can attract penalties, the official said. This has encouraged them to procure expensive electricity through the government's Discovery of Efficient Electricity Price (DEEP) portal, an e-bidding and reverse-auction platform for short-term power procurement.

While discoms typically meet most of their requirements via long-term power purchase pacts, which can span 25 years, they turn to exchanges and competitive bidding for additional supplies.

Unlike exchanges, where procurement depends on available sell bids and prevailing market conditions, short-term contracts allow discoms to secure specified quantities for agreed periods, offering greater certainty of supply.

Power shortages crossed the 30 million units per day mark in September while the month's deficit stood at 560 million units, the highest in three years.

"Amid El Niño impact and economic growth, demand shot up this year and was higher than the supplies; therefore, we saw more bilateral trading," said Lokesh Chandra, chairman and managing director, Maharashtra State Electricity Distribution Company Ltd (MSEDCL).

An executive at an Assam-based utility said states like Rajasthan and Bihar have directly offered around ₹22 per unit for procurement and have asked utilities not to sell on exchanges.

Rohit Bajaj, joint managing director, Indian Energy Exchange (IEX) said rising electricity consumption led to higher procurement across power exchanges and bilateral markets, as distribution companies and other market participants stepped up purchases.

"At IEX, electricity traded volumes grew 16.5% year-on-year (in October), underscoring the growing role of power exchanges in meeting India's electricity demand through ease of transactions and transparent price discovery. Demand-supply dynamics also varied during the month due to changing weather conditions. Discoms and commercial and industrial consumers leveraged the real-time market to respond to these fluctuations and manage their power procurement in near real time." He added that with the onset of cooler weather in November, supply liquidity on the exchanges has increased.

Some discoms are tying up power through bilateral trade for the coming months at prices of up to ₹41.50 per unit

Queries mailed to the union ministry of power and Power Exchange of India Ltd on Wednesday remained unanswered till press time.

The scramble for supplies is continuing beyond the summer, with some discoms tying up power through bilateral trade for the coming months at prices of up to ₹41.50 per unit.

Further, in anticipation of high winter demand, several discoms have tied up for power through bilateral trade at as high as ₹41.5 per unit. Utilities in Tamil Nadu, Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, Karnataka, Delhi and Maharashtra have floated tenders for additional supplies for January-March and April-June.

The Tamil Nadu Generation and Distribution Corp. Ltd. sought additional supplies at ₹8.50-₹41.50 per unit from 1 November 2026 to 30 May 2027. For November, it invited bids for 1,000MW but awarded contracts for only 377MW, of which 20MW was secured at ₹35 per unit and 357MW at ₹37.50 per unit.

Gujarat Urja Vikas Nigam Ltd tied up additional supplies for November 2026-June 2027 at ₹8.98-₹35 per unit, according to data on the DEEP portal. Rajasthan Urja Vikas Nigam Ltd sought power for November-June at ₹8.40-₹19.75 per unit, while Karnataka State Electricity Board Ltd tied up supplies for November and December at up to ₹20 per unit.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Retention is the real test for India's consumer AI wave

FROM PAGE 1

tion points, rather than those that simply deliver information, she added.

For many first-time users, specialized apps serve as an entry point. Viswanathan at Kae Capital, noted that pre-investment surveys for SuperLiving revealed many users had never used a general-purpose AI tool. "We believe a platform like SuperLiving will actually be their gateway to AI," she said.

Unlike earlier consumer-internet businesses, these start-ups can build on established payments and advertising systems while using AI to deliver services, Viswanathan said. Investors and founders believe AI can make education, wellness and wealth-management services more affordable through personalised, ongoing assistance previously dependent on human advisers.

For instance, Supernova provides conversational English practice with an AI tutor supporting 11 Indian languages, priced at ₹299 per month.

SuperLiving designs customized wellness plans using medical history and daily routines, charging ₹349 to ₹1199 per month for weight-loss, nutrition, and skincare modules. Co-founder Manavdeep Singh

The premise of consumer AI is convenience. AFP

Grover said the platform has served around 200,000 paying users to date.

To offset seasonal slumps in gym and weight-loss interest, SuperLiving expanded into skincare and regionalized content. "The app uses proprietary data on regional foods and habits, alongside local-language support, to tailor guidance to users," Grover said, adding that feedback loops on user compliance help refine its coaching models.

In hiring, Profound.me uses voice interface to screen job seekers, creating AI avatars for recruiter evaluation while simultaneously parsing employer requirements. "Feedback on which candidates employers accept or reject helps improve future recommendations," said co-founder Anuj Rathi, noting that monetization via employer recruitment fees helps subsidize candidate-facing compute costs.

Unlike traditional software businesses, AI startups face compute unit economics driven by "inference"—the ongoing cost of generating answers via large language models. Providers often charge by tokens, units of information processed. Even as token prices fall, bills can rise with more users, longer conversations and more past interactions processed to personalise responses.

To keep inference costs in check, Profound uses task-specific models rather than a single heavy architecture for voice and text processing. SuperLiving relies on an optimized memory indexing system to reduce the token volume processed per query. Localizing infrastructure has also helped: hosting models on domestic servers has brought down baseline compute costs, according to industry executives.

Despite higher gross margin pressure, early-stage investors appear willing to give startups room to maneuver on unit economics if retention holds steady.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

AIRTEL WILL BE DEBT-FREE BY 2029. BUYBACKS NEXT?

Sunil Bharti Mittal, 50 years as an entrepreneur, is next betting on AI, data centres and financial services to fuel growth

Jatin Grover & Josey Puliyenthuruthel
NEW DELHI

Sunil Bharti Mittal, founder and chairman of Bharti Enterprises.

As Sunil Bharti Mittal, founder and chairman of Bharti Enterprises Ltd, which owns telecom company Airtel, completes 50 years in business this year, he reflects on the journey, the decisions that shaped the group and the challenges of building businesses across sectors, in a conversation with *Mint* at his New Delhi office.

"To start from the ground up and create a $120 billion enterprise, for me it's not going to be possible (at this stage)," said Mittal, 69, reflecting on the scale of what has been built and the limits of starting afresh at this stage of his career.

He also discussed Airtel's future, tariff hikes, investments in artificial intelligence (AI) and data centres, the group's other businesses, and his views on succession planning at the company.

Edited excerpts:

You said you would retire at 50.

No, not retire; I would never retire. I had said I would go into politics or something away from business.

Recently, you brought back the entry-level tariff plan. Usually, tariff hikes are followed by peers. Why did it not work out, this time?

The market is so competitive that you cannot stand alone beyond a point. Today, most of my plans command a premium, but there is a limit to how far we can go. You cannot have a supreme premium in a very difficult, competitive market.

In our case, you can consume whatever you want. If you actually want all of Jio's traffic to come to me, I will take it. I have the capacity, and vice versa. So the capacities are unlimited. Vodafone Idea does not move, as you know, because it sells with a lot of difficulties, and if Jio does not move, then it gets difficult. We tried, but it is an experiment.

What about the target of reaching around ₹400 Arpu (average revenue per user)? How will you get there?

We need to reach ₹350. India's whole quest to become a digital powerhouse over the next 10–15 years requires massive compute capacity and zillions of AI agents on the network. You need a much stronger network than we have today. That means more fibre, more subsea cables, more space technologies coming in, and mobile radios.

China has over a million towers; India has 350,000 today. We have to get to 600,000–700,000 towers, which means doubling from where we are today. We need serious financial capacity to do it. The upper end, which is stuck at ₹400–500, can easily go up to ₹600, ₹700. We have kept it artificially all free, unlimited at ₹400–500. That is the broken architecture.

Will tariff hikes ultimately be decided by the market leader, Jio?

No, Jio cannot move without... if he moves and we don't, he is toast. The industry has to do it. But if the industry says, I want to kill you before I get to nirvana, that does not work. Even Vodafone Idea is out there; BSNL is out there.

Across Bharti Enterprises' 50-year journey spanning telecom, space, hospitality, and real estate, what are your biggest bets outside of telecom?

There were multiple experiments that we started; we could not scale any one of them like telecom, and two or three of them had potential.

One was retail, clearly, with Walmart, which started very well; we opened up a lot of stores—both cash-and-carry and retail—and insurance.

> 'There were multiple experiments that we started; we could not scale any one of them like telecom'

But our focus could not move to those businesses away from telecom because almost every time we thought we could put more money, more capital, more resources into other businesses, we had fires burning here.

One by one, we exited software and skilling businesses, which were too sub-scale. Our insurance company went to ICICI Lombard, and for life insurance, we are now bringing in Prudential to really fire up their engine with 75% equity.

Real estate, we will carry on doing ourselves. And then we have invested in Haier, where Warburg Pincus and we took a 49% stake; we got 25%, and we will stay in this. Hospitality is a big business, which is mostly outside India.

Telecom is now the large mainstay that will remain largely the way it is today, very professionally run, with stewards of the shareholders. There, we are going to do big bets. Data centres, AI data centres, I think billions of dollars will go there.

And the third is financial services. We have Airtel Payments Bank, we have Airtel Money in Africa, which has got listed on the FTSE 100, and we have just started Airtel Money here as a non-banking financial company for lending to our customers.

What are the plans for listing Nxtra (the data centre business) and Airtel Payments Bank?

For the size of our group, having a company listed with a very small market capitalization just doesn't sit well with the system. So the scale is important. [With] Nxtra, our ambition is by 2030 to get to 1 gigawatt. We have 250-260 megawatts, so it's 4x from where we are today. So it will take 3-4 years, and then we could be ready.

Payments Bank, same, we are about ₹4,000 crore in revenue, ₹4,000 crore in deposits. It is profitable. So, some of these bets could be looking interesting to list in 2030.

In terms of raising capital, do you think you have enough on the books to spend?

Airtel's balance sheet has never been better. At one point in time when things were really tough, we were coming closer to four times debt to Ebitda (earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation, and amortization). Today, we are less than one.

And if you do the projection, by 2029, we'll be a debt-free company. And if you're generating $14–15 billion Ebitda, your capacity to borrow is huge. So I don't see us doing any more rights or fresh issues and all that. The company would be in a position to start buybacks.

How big is real estate as part of your portfolio?

I would say the entire Aerocity (a business and hospitality complex near Delhi airport), which is going on at the moment, the entire project would be in the vicinity of about ₹10,000 crore. It is the largest mall in India; it's the largest business district. We are building nearly 13–14 million square feet there under Worldmark and high-quality assets.

We don't go into land conversion and all the state issues. We take part in government auctions. It is a very clean business model; we do not want to go into areas where we have to get land conversion—buy land from farmers and all that. We don't want that.

Can the second peak be taller than the first peak in businesses when you do other businesses?

I can only talk about my lifetime, the peak that we have built. You can only keep on building on top of that. To start something grounds-up and to create a $120-billion enterprise, for me, it's not going to be possible (at this stage).

Your competitor calls itself a technology company. What's next for Bharti, and what are your thoughts on getting into AI tokenization?

We don't manufacture any equipment; we buy equipment. Similarly, we will buy bare-metal servers and GPUs (graphics processing units) and bring them in for the benefit of our customers.

So we were selling minutes, and we are selling bits, GBs, and tomorrow the world is going to be tokens; we will be doing that.

What we have is customer relationships, brand, trust, and therefore we will deploy this equipment, and that's why the AI data centre and our cloud operations team will roll this out for sovereign needs, for our enterprise customers.

And for retail customers, we are not doing our own LLMs (large language models), but when you consume ChatGPT or Claude or Grok, you will need to connect through a network here. And at that time, can I add value by maybe offering an opportunity to switch to an open-weight model, as opposed to Claude or GPT, to lower your token costs?

Why were phones your first manufacturing business? Why not retail? Why not something else?

(Mittal had begun assembling push-button phones in India in 1985, which eventually steered him towards the telecom sector.)

It could have been anything. But I was very clear that I had to do things that others didn't do in India, and I had to bring new things because the big boys had given you no space in those days. There was no startup culture. You either become a supplier to them, a trader, or do small things; you couldn't be in their space.

What were the constraints in looking at other businesses other than Sunil Mittal's time?

I think it's basically time and attention and some more money. And do remember one thing: to kickstart a project even today, I would say you need an entrepreneur; you can't have professionals starting from the ground-up; it's very hard. You need that maniacal determination, day in, day out, Sunday, no family, no home, travelling on a plane, on a train; that is necessary to build from the ground up. Professionals can acquire and then improvise, but from ground zero it is tough.

In the satcom (satellite communications) space, approvals are pending. What is the delay costing Eutelsat OneWeb?

We have put the investment into the ground stations. There are two ground stations. There is a smaller team here, but total revenue from India for OneWeb in a year will be $15–20 million. It's a nice one; it's not a big deal. That's why we are patiently sitting down. (Bharti Enterprises is a major shareholder in Paris-headquartered Eutelsat Group, the parent company of satellite communications company Eutelsat OneWeb.)

Do you think there's a need to expedite the approvals?

I don't know what's causing the delay, but every time I think we're closer to a decision, there's a geopolitical issue, and these are not Indian networks; they are foreign networks. You saw what happened in Ukraine; they dialled down the speed. There were catastrophic consequences in the war.

> 'By 2029, we'll be debt-free. And if you're generating $14–15 billion Ebitda, your capacity to borrow is huge'

We seem to be just stuck because they (the government) have to open it for everybody. We don't have inter-satellite links, whereas, as you know, Starlink (operated by Elon Musk's SpaceX) has satellite links. They don't need to come down, they can just be in space, they can deal there. Much more sophisticated satellites than ours, but it has security implications.

When Vodafone Idea completed the AGR (adjusted gross revenue) recalculation exercise, you talked about the need for a level-playing field. Airtel also has this history, and they are also sufferers there. Where are you on that? Have you stopped pursuing that with the government?

No, we keep pursuing it. In the end, I think the signal is that these are now matters in the legal domain. So we will take a decision now. But we are not seeking the entire Vodafone Idea-type package; they had the equity conversion, and they had other deferrals.

What we really are looking at is the calculation errors, the apparent errors that are there, which Vodafone Idea would have got relief on. That's the only thing we are working on. I mean, the rest we are not even pursuing because we are not in a state where we want to offer equity conversion.

Will you go to court then?

I don't know. The board or management has to make a decision, but hopefully in the next few months we should reach a conclusion.

What consumer insights do you wish you had 15–20 years ago that would have made your journey different?

This is one area where I would say, very proudly, we were very switched on to what customers need. Our insights into the customers' needs were always very good. This is where we are deeply connected to the market. We pay full attention to it, and this is the difference between Airtel's success and many other companies' failure.

Yes, Jio came with free services for a year; then you have nothing to respond to. We tried to manage through that period with great difficulty, and you saw the stock price went to ₹220; things were quite shaky in 2017-18, but somehow we knew the playbook, we knew exactly how long this would last, and you just had to hold on.

Did Mukesh Ambani congratulate you 10 years later?

(Smiles) I also say, what he has done is also the world's first. And he has made us better, no questions.

Give us a big view on succession at Bharti.

This is a different experiment. I have never seen any company having such high empowerment in the hands of professionals. We spend ₹35,000 crore a year in India, another ₹10,000 crore in Africa. I don't get to sign 10 paise. And that kind of empowerment makes them (company professionals) the owners, and they are responsible for their decisions.

Every time a storm comes, the professional team looks for leadership. At companies like British Telecom or Unilever, they will look to the board. In India, they look to a shareholder, a steward; I happen to be a founder, a manager, a shareholder, and a steward.

The next generation will not be the founder. They may not even be the operators, since they are doing their own thing. But I am very confident that they will be good stewards. They will be very respectful of the model I have created and the value system they grew up with. They know that it's a win-win situation. If we continue to keep this model going, it's good for them as well, and I and the family will win anyway.

In non-Airtel businesses, the family is building up; they are the promoters; they are the founders.

Shravin (Bharti Mittal) is running his tech fund. He has gone to the Africa board now as a deputy chairman under Gopal Vittal (executive vice chairman of Bharti Airtel). In a few years, he could be ready to take over the chair.

Kavin (Bharti Mittal), after Hike, is looking at his next fix in the area of technology. He will come up with something. He is talking to Gopal and the team about AI, compute, LLMs, and new energy. (Shravin and Kavin are Sunil Bharti Mittal's twin sons.)

My daughter (Eiesha Bharti Pasricha) is in the hospitality business with my son-in-law (Sharan Pasricha). They run 200 hotels.

Existing businesses—real estate—I don't see anybody interested. So there are some businesses that will be run through professionals. It's kind of a setup, clearly delineated from a typical family-business model.

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Breathe in, budget out: the real cost of owning a home air purifier

With pollution becoming a year-round concern, here's how much households need to set aside for cleaner air

Ananya Grover
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MUMBAI

For many Indian families, clean air has become a budget item, with spending on air purifiers and treatment for pollution-triggered respiratory problems.

From Srinagar in the north to Andhra Pradesh in the south, India's air quality map as of 6 November showed unhealthy to hazardous pollution across regions well beyond the seasonal smog in the National Capital Region (NCR).

A July 2024 study published in *The Lancet Planetary Health* showed that air pollution is no longer just a Delhi problem, with PM2.5, fine particles that can penetrate deep into the lungs and bloodstream, posing a major health risk across large parts of India.

Seasonal factors such as stubble burning and winter weather trap pollutants close to the ground, creating dense smog across North India from October to February. But the study points to a broader, year-round threat from urban pollution due to vehicle exhaust, industries, thermal power plants and construction. These local emissions are particularly toxic, raising daily death rates across 10 major cities even on days when air quality met India's official safety limits.

Ronak Sutaria, founder and chief executive of climate tech startup Respirer Living Sciences, said growing awareness of PM2.5 has prompted many people to buy air purifiers, particularly for their bedrooms. As these become a regular household expense, understanding their costs is important.

Owning the right purifier

Most buyers, Sutaria said, look for a HEPA filter, preferably H13 grade, and then choose a model in their budget. But performance depends largely on the clean air delivery rate (CADR), which measures the volume of filtered air a purifier delivers. A mismatch between the CADR and room size can render the device ineffective.

As a rule of thumb, he said a CADR of up to 200 cubic metres per hour suits a room of about 250 square feet. A bigger room needs more machines, which is why many homes end up with two or three purifiers.

His price guide, based on evaluations his team has done, suggests that purifiers costing less than ₹10,000 are usually suited to rooms smaller than about 100 square feet and for rooms bigger than 150 square feet, a decent one can cost between ₹12,000 and ₹18,000.

Cheaper models tend to have a low CADR, a weaker filter or a low-powered motor, and for purifiers that cost more than ₹20,000, "you're paying for aesthetics, not for functionality," he said, adding that the filter itself should capture 99.9% of particles at the PM 2.5 level.

Maintenance costs

Rajan Rawal, professor at CEPT University and senior adviser to the Centre for Advanced Research in Building Science and Energy (CRDF), said operating a 30-40 W living room air purifier consumes 12-15 kWh of electricity monthly. While energy costs are minimal, the primary expense is replacing specialized HEPA and activated carbon filters whose costs vary by manufacturer and technology.

Localized residential purification systems offer minimal initial capital expenditure, but their long-term operational expenditures, driven by cumulative electricity consumption and recurring filter replacements across multiple rooms, are financially inefficient, he added.

To address maintenance beyond periodic filter replacement, extended warranty and protection plans typically range from ₹599 to over ₹1,400, depending on the device's purchase price and the coverage duration. It covers functional parts like fan motors, blower assemblies, and air quality sensors, along with repair and logistics costs, but excludes consumables and replaceable wear items such as HEPA or carbon filters, pre-filters, physical or liquid/water damage, and power surge/voltage fluctuation issues.

Long warranties and service plans are not worth paying extra for, according to Sutaria.

He said an air purifier has only two parts that matter: a filter and a motor, so long warranties and service plans are not worth paying extra for, since filters are not covered and, in most cases, the motor warranty does not include physical damage or voltage fluctuations.

He suggested budgeting about ₹2,000 a year to change the filter, which users can do themselves. A good purifier's motor should last three to five years, he added, and if you run it continuously, he suggested switching it off for half an hour in the middle of the day.

Put together, a ₹12,000 to ₹18,000 purifier plus ₹2,000 a year for filters and about ₹336 a year for electricity comes to roughly ₹19,000 to ₹25,000 over three years, provided that the purifier itself does not need fixing during this period.

Some people in Delhi rent purifiers only during the most polluted months, which cost around ₹400-₹700 per month. Sutaria said rentals can be cost-effective but warns users to check that the filter is not sealed in plastic bags.

Cheaper investment

For urban households battling bad air, purchasing an air purifier is fast becoming an essential insurance policy, as the cost looks cheaper and less taxing compared to medical bills and hospital visits.

Aditya Nag, assistant professor and consultant pulmonologist at Noida International Institute of Medical Sciences, said that hospital admission in case of a respiratory attack for the most vulnerable people can easily cost ₹50,000-₹1 lakh at a good hospital, and emergency department admission can further cost ₹10,000-₹15,000.

The costs go beyond the hospitalized period in terms of loss of working days and other therapies that may be required if the disease is chronic, he added. There is a misconception that only smokers face lung diseases, but the majority are those who are exposed to pollution.

He advised avoiding going out during peak pollution hours, keeping doors and windows closed, getting coughs and colds treated, and buying an air purifier for the room where you spend most of your time.

Sutaria said people should consider filter replacement costs, the outdoor environment and energy efficiency before buying an air purifier. Additionally, he said one common mistake is closing every window and door and running the purifier, which causes PM 2.5 to come down while carbon dioxide (CO_2) builds up quickly, even with just two or three people in the room.

A purifier removes particles, not CO_2, so the room can still feel stuffy. "If you are locking up the room from outdoor air, you will need some form of mechanical ventilation to keep CO_2 low, as low CO_2 levels are essential for cognitive tasks and better REM sleep," he said.

How to budget for it

Preeti Zende, Sebi-registered investment adviser and founder of Apanadhan Financial Services, called air purifiers a precautionary expense and suggested planning and budgeting for it in advance. She added that if the need is driven by necessity, people can use their credit card and be disciplined about honouring the EMIs or the amount due.

What she said is extremely important is having health insurance covering all family members separate from the one provided by an employer and slowly building an emergency medical kitty to cover all the peripheral expenses. This can either be parked in a debt or arbitrage fund, or if it is for the long term, in an equity savings or a balanced advantage fund.

Rawal said that the most cost-effective and long-term solution is to create and maintain urban habitats with an Air Quality Index (AQI) below an acceptable level. He said that the high initial capital expenditure required to install centralized mechanical systems is offset by significantly lower per-unit operational costs over the buildings' lifecycle.

Scan the QR code to read an extended version of this story.

How much does it cost to keep your home pollution-free?

Room size, clean air delivery rate and filtration requirements determine how many machines you need. Here's a breakdown of the costs.

Cost breakdown

Room floor area	No. of purifiers	Capital cost (₹)	Cost per sq. ft (₹)	Energy cost per month (₹)
Up to 325 sq. ft	1	8,500	26	28
520 sq. ft	2	17,000	33	56
650 sq. ft	2	17,000	26	56
970 sq. ft	3	25,500	26	84

Note: Cost of periodic filter replacement is excluded. The costs depend on room size, CADR (volume of clean air delivered per hour) and ACH (number of times room air is changed per hour). The table assumes a CADR of 450 m^3/hr per purifier and at least five air changes per hour (ACH), based on a 3-metre ceiling height. Larger rooms or higher filteration requirements may need more powerful or additional purifiers and the actual cost may vary depending on room height, ventilation, usage, or manufacturer.
Source: Respirer Living Sciences

Buyer checklist

- **CADR (Clean Air Delivery Rate):** Choose a CADR suited to your room size. A higher CADR means faster delivery of filtered air.
- **Room coverage:** Check the recommended room size and the ceiling height assumed by the manufacturer.
- **Filter quality:** Look for HEPA filtration (H13 or equivalent independently verified performance) to capture fine particles such as PM2.5.
- **Filter replacement cost:** Check the price and availability of replacement filters and how frequently they need changing.
- **Check power** consumption and noise levels
- **Know what** the warranty covers and weigh the benefits before purchasing extended warranty plans
- **Focus on** functionality not just on aesthetics
- **Build a** financial kitty for medical emergencies

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POWER POINT
KAPIL MEHTA

Respond to this column at
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WHY RENEWING YOUR INSURANCE ON TIME MATTERS

Some weeks ago, I took stock of my personal insurance. I had 12 policies: two term plans, five health covers, two home and office policies, two motor insurances and a liability cover. I also have the distinction of having a renewal due in every month of the year. Keeping track of them is hard but critical. Renewing on time matters because I want to be "on risk" at all times, without any surprises. Less obviously, a break in renewal can mean losing benefits built over many years.

A lapse in term or health insurance can trigger fresh health checks, higher premiums or rejection of cover. In motor insurance, cover resumes only after a car inspection, with existing damage potentially excluded. Driving without mandatory third-party cover is an offence, while a lapse beyond 90 days resets the no-claim bonus. A break in liability cover can leave claims from past incidents uncovered.

The grace period

Term and health policies offer a grace period of up to 30 days for annual premiums. Renewing within this period preserves waiting periods served and the no-claim bonus. Term insurance covers death during the grace period, deducting the unpaid premium from the payout. However, many health policies exclude hospitalization during the gap. Motor, home and liability policies offer no grace period. A grace period helps only if you know you have missed a payment. A colleague's health insurance renewal failed because of an e-payment glitch. She found out only when she went to claim for a minor surgery. She now has a new policy but has lost all her waiting-period benefits.

Six ways to stay covered

Set up auto-pay. You can do this through your credit card or a NACH e-mandate on your bank account. Once active, you usually receive an alert by email, WhatsApp or SMS before payment is taken. The policy renews even if you forget or miss the reminders. You simply need to ensure that the account has sufficient funds or the card has enough credit limit. Card mandates above ₹1 lakh require an OTP each time, so a large premium may not renew automatically.

A renewal lapse can mean losing benefits, paying high premiums or even being denied cover

Pay electronically. It retains proof of when you paid. With cheques, you may hand one over on time, but the agent or insurer could deposit it late.

Use your own contact details. Put your own email address and phone number on the policy. Many policies carry the salesperson's contact details or a number that is no longer in use. Insurers usually start renewal reminders about two months before the due date, with messages becoming more urgent as the date approaches. Register for WhatsApp communication, too, as policy copies are often sent through it. Then set your own email or calendar reminder for 30 days before each due date.

Keep digital copies. Store current policies in one folder and old ones in a separate sub-folder. DigiLocker and Bima Central are alternatives. On Bima Central, you enter the insurer's name and policy number, and the app retrieves the policy electronically and sends reminders. You need to update it each time you renew, which can be cumbersome when the policy number changes every year. Either way, tell your family where the policies are stored so nominees can find them.

Prefer annual policies. We remember an event that recurs every year far better than one that takes place every three years. A multi-year health policy offers a discount and locks in the price for its term. To me, the cost of a missed renewal is far greater.

Confirm the renewal. Finally, check that the renewed policy reaches you. Auto-debits can fail and cards can expire. That is what happened to my colleague.

Many readers will be wondering why I have so many policies in the first place. In my defence, these include base policies, top-ups and separate covers for some family members. I am rationalizing my insurance, mainly on the health side, where some older policies are no longer meaningful. Those are my planned lapses.

Kapil Mehta is co-founder of SecureNow Insurance Broker.

'Choose credit based on your repayment capacity and needs'

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MUMBAI

Gold loan has emerged as one of India's fastest-growing retail credit products, with the outstanding loan book reaching ₹22.5 trillion and 5.5 crore customers as of August 2026, according to the November report by TransUnion CIBIL, a credit information company. As part of the *Mint Money Guru* series, Bhavesh Jain, MD and CEO of TransUnion CIBIL, highlights how repeat borrowing is shaping the segment, why borrowers should watch their cash flows, and which habits keep credit scores healthy.

MONEY GURU

How big is the gold loan market now, and have you seen defaults rise?

Gold loans have grown in both volume and value over the last three years, with more people borrowing and an increase in gold prices. As of August 2026, the outstanding book shows it is the second-largest retail credit product in India after mortgages. The 90-plus-day past-due rate is 0.3%, compared with 1.3% across retail credit, as lenders can liquidate the pledged gold in the event of default, limiting potential losses. However, the rate has doubled from 0.16% in March 2026. While it is lower than a year ago, the increase over five months is a trend to watch.

Why would you say borrowers in this segment engage in repeat borrowing, and what are the risks?

It is the biggest emerging trend. Among low-risk borrowers studied, 57% of consumers who took gold loans of ₹2.5 lakh or less took another gold loan within 12 months. The corresponding figure was 54% for loans above ₹2.5 lakh.

Gold loans recorded the highest repeat-origination rates among the liquidity-oriented credit products studied. Additionally, during the quarter ended June, 67% of consumers who originated gold loans already had an existing gold loan in their credit portfolios. Almost 37% of gold loan customers have four or more gold loan accounts. While the research establishes the extent of repeat borrowing, the reasons can vary across consumers.

Repeat originations may also include renewals or top-ups. What is important is that borrowers assess their repayment capacity before taking additional credit, while lenders consider their overall credit exposure and repayment history alongside the value of the pledged gold.

Gold prices fell recently. How does it impact borrowers?

The gold loan book has kept growing even as prices fell, because repeat borrowers keep increasing their exposure. Customers are taking on more, not less. They need to understand the underlying asset against which they are borrowing, as gold prices can fluctuate significantly within a month, a quarter or a year. These price fluctuations are a risk that every retail borrower should factor in before taking a gold loan.

Personal loans growth has drawn a lot of attention from lenders and regulators. What are you seeing in delinquency trends over the last 12 to 18 months?

Our analysis of credit bureau data indicates an improvement in repayment performance over the past year, even as lending activity has increased. We are also seeing improvement in the repayment behaviour of newer borrowers.

While these trends are encouraging, lenders must independently assess a borrower's overall financial position, including existing credit obligations, repayment history and capacity to service additional debt. Consumers, meanwhile, should ensure that monthly repayment commitments remain manageable.

How should a borrower decide between a personal loan, a gold loan and a credit card for a short-term financial need?

The choice of credit should primarily depend on three factors: the purpose of borrowing, the amount required and the borrower's ability to repay within a defined period. Each product serves different financial requirements, and consumers should understand its costs and repayment terms before making a decision.

> Price fluctuations are a risk that every retail borrower should factor in before taking a gold loan
> **Bhavesh Jain**
> MD and CEO, TransUnion CIBIL

A credit card can be useful for short-term purchases, particularly when the consumer can repay the entire outstanding bill by the due date and benefit from the applicable interest-free period. However, carrying forward unpaid balances can result in substantial interest charges.

A personal loan provides access to funds without pledging an asset and typically comes with fixed monthly instalments over an agreed tenure. Consumers should evaluate the interest rate, processing fees and total repayment obligation before opting for one.

A gold loan allows consumers to access funds against gold they already own without selling the asset. The loan amount depends on the valuation of the pledged gold and the lender's applicable loan-to-value limits.

While it provides a secured borrowing option, consumers must understand the repayment structure, interest charges and consequences of default, including the risk of losing the pledged gold. Consumers should compare available options, review the terms and conditions, consider existing financial commitments and borrow only what they can comfortably repay.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

THE MISSING MIDDLE: WHAT YOUR PORTFOLIO IS LACKING

Equities offer growth potential, while traditional savings provide familiarity and stability. But is there a missing middle in your investment portfolio? Could bonds help bridge this gap? In an interactive Q&A session, Nikhil Aggarwal challenges common myths around bonds offering 10-14%, and explores how they work, their role in portfolio diversification and how they complement existing investments. Discover why bonds are gaining attention among Indian investors, what is driving their growing adoption and whether they deserve a place in your investment portfolio.

Nikhil Aggarwal
Founder & Group CEO
Grip Invest

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OUR VIEW

MINT

The road ahead for the insurance regulator

The Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority has done well to highlight the mis-selling by distributors. It must now bring transparency in products to shield the consumer

Nearly 26 years after it was formed, the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (Irdai) seems ready to shift focus from developing the industry to holding it accountable. In its consultation paper on distribution reforms, the regulator laid bare an endemic problem: insurance products are being mis-sold to consumers, while commissions to the intermediaries are growing faster than the industry that pays for it.

Mint has long argued that life insurance policies are sold as investment traps with only a sliver of insurance, leaving customers to abandon them midway while intermediaries walk away with impunity. The issue is particularly acute with banks, which have forced insurance onto borrowers and sold bundled insurance-cum-investment plans to ill-informed customers. Banks are among the largest distributors of financial products, and insurance offers some of the steepest commissions. Yet, selling more life insurance plans has not translated into adequate protection for policyholders.

According to Irdai's latest statistical handbook, life insurers' assets under management more than tripled to ₹67.79 trillion in the decade ended fiscal 2025. Annual premium income rose 170% to ₹8.86 trillion over the period, driven by rising ticket sizes. Yet, individual active policies barely moved, rising 0.2% to 326.9 million. This near-stagnation deserves attention, especially as Irdai's consultation paper puts 61st month persistency at just 48%, meaning fewer than half of eligible policies remain active (*in force*) at that point.

For an industry built on long-term protection, this points to systemic failure. Fixing distribution is necessary, but so is product reform. The protection gap is stark. A 2022 Swiss Re estimate places protection available as a share of protection needed at 9.2%. The industry's growth numbers hide the fact that a large chunk of its customer base abandons policies it never understood. Health insurance is emerging as another problem area. Its share in complaints reaching the insurance ombudsman more than doubled in five years to reach 62% in fiscal 2025. More than half the complaints across various grievance redressal platforms are decided in policyholders' favour, suggesting that customers have to fight insurers for a fair outcome. This raises questions about how insurers treat customers and how intermediaries sell policies that appear to serve neither the customer nor the insurer.

Customers are also feeling the strain of rising health insurance premiums. Here, too, the numbers raise questions: retail premiums have risen faster than group premiums, even though group policies have a higher claims ratio. Are retail customers paying more to subsidize group cover?

Irdai's move to contain distribution costs is a welcome start. So is its decision to bring consumer representatives onto its Insurance Advisory Committee. Customers need insurance products they can understand, disclosures they can trust, and a regulator that holds insurers to account. Irdai's reports suggest it has the resources to strengthen oversight. Having taken the first step on distribution, the regulator must now put accountability at the centre of reform. A good place to start would be to make consumer-facing disclosures more meaningful and standardize the information insurers already report.

MY VIEW | FARM TRUTHS

Why India urgently requires its own official estimates of poverty

The World Bank estimates being flaunted have flaws owing to survey- and data-related anomalies

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The release of the *India Poverty and Equity Brief* in October by the World Bank has brought the poverty debate back in focus. The earlier release was in June last year which had estimates of poverty in India for 2022-23. This release has only updated the estimates using the 2023-24 data. However, unlike previous years, the last two releases have received a lot of attention. Partly because these appear to be endorsed by the government, with several functionaries using them to showcase poverty reduction during this government's tenure.

But the World Bank estimates are not official estimates of poverty by the government. India has been a pioneer in the measurement of poverty, with the erstwhile Planning Commission setting the poverty line and releasing official estimates. Unfortunately, with the government junking the Rangarajan committee report, for the first time India does not have an official poverty line. Consumption Expenditure Surveys (CES), which form the basis of poverty estimates, have also met a similar fate—the 2017-18 survey was withdrawn by the government after being approved by the National Statistical Commission (NSC). The consumption surveys were restarted as the Household Consumption Expenditure Survey (HCES) in 2022-23. Despite their availability, the government hasn't constituted a committee to set poverty lines suited for India, with the result that the World Bank estimates are being used. But how credible are these estimates?

The World Bank estimates are like any other international database maintained by multilateral institutions. However, given the complexity of comparisons across countries with varied measures of consumption or income, different exchange rates, differences in the methodology of data collection and differences in the conceptual basis of these measures, these are not suited to track poverty reduction in any individual country. Precisely why India also used its own poverty line set in domestic currency and anchored to a norm that reflected the minimum basic needs of the country. This was done through debate within the government, with experts, academics and civil society. The World Bank poverty line, on the other hand, is a median of a select group of countries, which change in every successive revision. This is further complicated by the use of International Comparison Programme purchasing power parity exchange rates, whose ability to capture specific country consumption patterns and prices is uncertain.

But the differences in consumption measures and their availability also implies that the measures used by the World Bank keep changing. For example, it used Consumer Pyramid data until 2025 for tracking poverty in India. While it shifted to using the latest HCES data, it is not fully comparable to the earlier CES statistics. This was because the HCES was carried out differently, with the survey split in three and each part carried out at a monthly interval. It also changed the sampling design substantially. But the World Bank went a step further by changing from the concept of consumption that it used until 2025 to what it refers to as 'real welfare.'

The new measure captures welfare, which is conceptually entirely different from the Indian practice since independence. While it may have relevance at the international level, some of the adjustments are questionable in the Indian context. For example, it excludes expenditure on durables, furniture and medical expenses but includes some items that are provided free to households such as food, textbooks and uniforms. Whether these represent the level of living is a matter of debate but it is not consistent with the way poverty has been measured in India.

The World Bank poverty estimates and poverty lines may suffice for political rhetoric, but India needs its own poverty line that is anchored to a basic minimum need consumption basket. It also needs its own measure of consumption that considers the specificity of India's consumption patterns.

For India, the poverty line was not just a broad metric of measuring progress over time, but was also an essential input to policymaking. Poverty estimates have been used by successive finance commissions for devolution and allocations across states for various poverty alleviation programmes. Most of these are still based on the 2011-12 estimates.

Given the challenges of policymaking in a heterogeneous country such as India, a poverty line by states and rural and urban areas separately is a necessity for any meaningful policy analysis.

QUICK READ

The World Bank's poverty figures don't account for consumption patterns unique to India. Their shift to measuring 'real welfare' from consumption also reflects changes anomalous for India.

India needs its own poverty line, especially with consumption data now being available uniformly as part of the household surveys. This is crucial for effective policymaking.

10 YEARS AGO

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Mistry sought to formalize trusts' say in group firms

JUST A THOUGHT

"Insurance—an ingenious modern game of chance in which the player is permitted to enjoy the comfortable conviction that he is beating the man who keeps the table.

AMBROSE BIERCE

MY VIEW | ACUTE ANGLE

The US midterms: what truly mattered and what didn't

SANJOY CHAKRAVORTY

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The US midterm elections have delivered an unambiguous verdict. The Democratic Party won big. At the national level, it won back the Senate and the House of Representatives. At the state level, it won new governorships and state houses. Some victories were stunning, like in Senate races in deeply conservative South Carolina and Kansas, and a statewide sweep in Texas. The expert consensus is that it's a forceful rejection of Trump and Trumpism. There is also pride in the durability of US democracy.

There are many issues worthy of discussion, but what was it that truly mattered in this election and what didn't? The numbers presented are exit poll data from *NBC News* (*shorturl.at/clrgP*). Other polls reported roughly similar figures.

What truly mattered? In a word: money. The most important was the basic pocket-book issue, the cost of living. Forty-nine percent of people polled thought it was crucial and another 40% thought it was a major factor in their vote. The cost of living had four components: *First*, the attack on Iran which spiked the price of gasoline and diesel (and consequently food and groceries); *second*, the retaliation to Trump's tariffs that made exports more expensive, especially in the farm sector, and hurt the Republican Party's most devoted followers: older rural men; *third*, healthcare access and costs, which were severely affected by policies that almost obliterated Obamacare and closed hospitals, especially in rural areas; *fourth*, stubborn and cumulative inflation.

Voters blamed the Trump administration for all these challenges. The Iran war was a crucial (34%) or major (40%) factor in the voting decision as close to 90% of respondents were somewhat or very concerned about the prices of gasoline, diesel and food. Eighty-five percent felt similarly concerned about healthcare costs. Fifty-eight percent believed the Trump administration's policies had made the health and well-being of people in the US worse. Inflation caused severe or moderate hardship for 76% of families. Sixty-six percent believed Trump's tariffs had hurt the economy. Fear of AI—which 57% believe will hurt society—and distaste for data centres added to the economic anxiety. As a result, 37% of respondents were dissatisfied with, and another 39% angry, at how things were going in the country.

What also got electoral traction was corruption. Democrats made sure to point out the brazen enrichment of Trump and his family and friends in the last two years. Government corruption became a crucial (55%) or major (36%) factor in respondents' voting decision. So disillusioned was this electorate that given six choices to select the top overall concern, the "state of democracy" in the US ranked second (chosen by 33%). The economy at 39% was the top choice, of course.

Immigration was an important non-monetary factor. In fact, given how much vitriol is generated by this issue and how polarizing it is, the voters had a surprisingly positive approach to it. 61% believed that immigrants do more to help the US and 58% believed that the Trump administration's actions on immigration enforcement had gone too far. However, immigration may have been more significant in some regions than the national data indicates. It is likely that this administration's immigration enforcement policies created a big shift in Hispanic votes from centre to left and helped turn Texas blue.

Let's turn to issues that did not matter in this election. China and its growing superpower rivalry with the US did not matter. Neither did Israel or the genocide in Gaza. Russia and Ukraine? Non-factors. Kidnapping a president (Venezuela) or assassinating another leader (Iran) were immaterial. Barely 4% of the respondents picked foreign policy as the most important issue. Crime was picked by even fewer, 3%. Being "tough on crime" was a Republican hallmark. Either crime has disappeared from America or being "tough on immigration" is its contemporary variant.

The environment did not matter either. Climate change appeared to be less important than transgender bathroom use as a political issue. The environment was not even one of the six choices given to respondents to identify the most important issue. Neither was race relations. Nor poverty, inequality or abortion—arguably the single most important driver of Republican support lately. By attacking Iran, Trump changed the terms of the conversation and the Republican Party paid a heavy price. One could even argue that Iran won the American midterms.

Democrats tend to be better at channelling economic anxiety, whereas Republicans are masterful at manipulating cultural anxieties around race/ethnicity, gender, sexuality, religion and nationalism. This is the basic left-right divide in politics everywhere, including India. The economic distress in America is self-created—another endless war and mindless tariffs standing atop the list of self-sabotage. Trump had come to power by leveraging the pain of deindustrialization in middle America. Rather than relieving that pain, his actions added to it.

Trump and the Republicans forgot the iconic slogan invented during Bill Clinton's 1992 presidential run: "it's the economy, stupid." It is political shorthand for the primacy of pocketbook issues—inflation, gasoline prices, interest rates—in US elections (like the price of onions used to be in Indian elections). Only extreme hubris can ignore this simple principle of electoral politics.

QUICK READ

Basic pocket-book issues such as cost of living, gasoline prices and inflation were top of the mind for the US electorate. The current US administration's corruption also was a major factor.

What didn't matter? China's rivalry for one. Or Israel and the genocide in Gaza, or Russia and Ukraine. In short, 'It's the economy, stupid'. Trump would have done well to remember.

THEIR VIEW

The five stages of AI grief and where we are currently placed

Denial, anger, bargaining and depression over AI's capabilities have passed but much can yet be done about accepting its impact

DANI RODRIK
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AFP

People facing a diagnosis of terminal illness, the Swiss-American psychiatrist Elisabeth Kübler-Ross famously wrote, experience five stages of grief: denial, anger, bargaining, depression and acceptance. The same could also be said of our response to artificial intelligence's (AI) rapidly expanding capabilities.

At first, it seemed as if AI would not amount to more than a glorified search engine or a chatbot that does a decent job of simulating a human being. That made it easy enough to deny that the technology would have much impact on our lives or professions.

Then AI started cropping up everywhere, and in the most infuriating ways. Its influence appeared in lawyers' briefs with hallucinated case references; in software code with mistakes and security vulnerabilities; in customer-service bots that went off script; and in student essays and assignments. These were all good reasons for getting mad.

But then AI got better. The fabrications, hallucinations and mistakes grew rarer. As it became obvious that AI use by students was unstoppable, many started to see an upside in the technology's potential to enhance learning. It was time to negotiate. We would need to make all kinds of adjustments in how we worked, but we told ourselves that there were still inherent limits to what AI could do. It could undertake a vast amount of cognitive and analytical work, and much faster than any human; but questions of judgment, taste, values and preferences were still, and would remain, matters for the human mind. AI could execute, but we humans would imagine. It was just a matter of getting the division of labour right.

I clung to this view for quite some time, and it gave me much comfort. Alas, AI was not playing ball. Each time I asked my chatbot a question, it came back not only with answers, but with much more. It told me what else I should be looking for, suggested a different way of framing my approach, and offered a parallel or contrast with some other project on which I had worked (regardless of whether I had consulted AI on it or not). It was sort of annoying, but I could not deny that I was receiving valuable insights. I'd like to think that I would have arrived at similar thoughts on my own in due time, but my chatbot regularly pre-empted me. Worse still, it clearly could be very imaginative.

Inspired by my colleague Jason Furman's claim that AI tools would do a better job today than professionally trained economists in staff roles at the White House Council of Economic Advisers (CEA), I tested my chatbot with a difficult question: "It is 2027, and the country is faced with a crisis in care. There is a shortage of home care aides, accidents and deaths are rising among elderly and disabled people left without help, and workers are dropping out of the labor market to look after loved ones. The CEA Chair needs options to present to the President." I hit enter, and the AI promptly prepared a technical memo with detailed recommendations covering federal matching grants, adjustments to Medicaid pay, and a caregiver visa programme, complete with a fiscal accounting. Exceeding its authority (and, characteristically, the prompt itself), it also outlined a political strategy for selling the programme.

Hmm, I thought, my chatbot is clearly very good at operating within the prevailing economic and institutional context. But could it move beyond it? To answer that question, I asked it to develop some out-of-the-box policy alternatives, disregarding political realities. It came back with some interesting possibilities, including a National Care Corps that would draft young people to take care of the old, and converting underutilized office and mall space into "care districts" that would benefit from scale and agglomeration economies.

Then, on a whim, I asked AI to turn one of my manuscripts into a stand-up comedy routine. What came back made me laugh so hard that I worried about passers-by fearing for my mental health. Insight, imagination, humour! This was not part of our bargain, was it?

That is when the depression began to set in. I started to feel sadness about a world in which human thought would no longer be distinct from machine work—and would be needed less day by day. Like the mathematicians who signed a joint letter on the impact of AI on their field, I became alarmed about the loss of "conceptual understanding and insight" that would follow from letting AI take over our work. It was frightening and disorienting.

The next stage, the manual tells us, is acceptance. Here we do have a choice. Unlike a terminal illness, AI and its uses are not outside our control. From the Silicon Valley firms developing the technology and the businesses deploying it to the professional communities that set the norms of appropriate use and the governments that must one day (better sooner than later) regulate it, decisions are being made each day about our relationship to AI. The worst mistake we can make is to accept a world in which we cede too much to it.

Ultimately, we will have to figure out how we restrain the use of AI for the good of humanity. The appropriate analogy here is to performance-enhancing drugs, which temporarily increase human capabilities but eventually harm users. AI is similar, except that it is much more powerful, and its commensurately disastrous side effects will show up much later. The temptation to indulge in it freely is, and will remain, very strong.

Homer's Odysseus knew that the Sirens promised knowledge but delivered disaster. He had himself tied to the mast of his ship so that he would not succumb to their beautiful song and steer toward them and the cliffs that had claimed so many mariners. The challenge we face with AI is similar: to restrain ourselves from losing our humanity.

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QUICK READ

Like Elisabeth Kübler-Ross's five stages of grief, people first denied, then got angry, then bargained and eventually felt depressed over AI's abilities and potential to replace human work.

As for the fifth stage, acceptance, humanity still has a choice. AI and its uses are not out of human control and these must be regulated. Ceding too much to it would be a big mistake.

MINT CURATOR

Anthropic need not fret if its IPO value is close to $1 trillion

It is lower than the hoped-for $2 trillion but that's not a bad thing

CHRIS HUGHES
is a Bloomberg Opinion columnist covering deals.

Anthropic should want its shares to pop on debut. BLOOMBERG

Who should get to call the shots on Anthropic's initial public offering? The potential buyers, of course.

Artificial intelligence (AI) has not changed the fact that one can easily lose money on an initial public offering (IPO) and investors therefore deserve a corresponding chance to make a quick buck. Like all new stock sales, the Claude developer's deal needs to be priced to fly.

Anthropic's backers were reportedly seeking a $2 trillion valuation for the forthcoming listing back in August. The market backdrop is very different today.

Rising interest rates and a potential American policy shift on data centres following the [Democrat victory during] midterm elections have pummeled tech valuations. On Tuesday the company set a price range for the stock sale valuing Anthropic at up to $1.4 trillion using a full share count including stock options and other equity awards.

Investors have had their sights set on a number as low as $1.1 trillion, *Bloomberg News* reported last week. Recall that Anthropic was valued at just under $1 trillion in its last funding round in May.

Valuing Anthropic is a mind-bending challenge because there are no real comparator companies, the numbers are changing quickly and the pace at which sales will become sizeable earnings remains uncertain.

Revenue in the first nine months of 2026 was 13 times the total in the same period last year. The latest annualized run rate—a projection of 12-month revenue—is $81 billion. That is more than the yearly sales of the overwhelming majority of S&P 500 members. Despite its size, Anthropic still displays the high growth usually associated with a startup.

Investors do not generally buy an IPO for the revenue and profit it is making today; they look a few years out. Anthropic's annual sales could expand at a compound annual rate of over 40% starting in 2027, reaching nearly $270 billion in 2029 and generating some $70 billion of operating profit on an adjusted basis, excluding the impact of stock-based pay, Bloomberg Intelligence forecasts.

The 26% operating margin would still be humdrum compared to what the big tech firms report, a reminder that the fluent and plausible-sounding answers from AI chatbots need lots of expensive computing power to produce. Anthropic has locked itself into some chunky commitments to buy that so-called compute.

There are countless approaches to valuation here.

While the company is going to turn profitable soon, plenty of questions still remain over its revenue trajectory, and even more over the various ways of measuring profit. Setting valuation as a multiple of future revenue uses the least uncertain metric and has the advantage of being simple.

Alphabet, Meta and Microsoft trade at 5.4 to 9.5 times next year's sales. Fast forward two years and value Anthropic's prospective 2029 revenue on around 7.5 times and you get an enterprise value at the $2 trillion number that was tossed around earlier this year. Discounting that back at 15% annually would imply a $1.5 trillion present-day value.

Now apply a further discount because IPO investors expect to buy below fair value. Set that at 20% to 30% and you land on the hoped-for IPO price of about $1.1 trillion to $1.2 trillion that has been doing the rounds.

You can get to higher valuations by applying a more growth-centric revenue multiple or by using a lower discount rate. The market for AI services could keep expanding through the next decade and Anthropic could take a hefty slice assuming it retains a leading technological position and pricing power.

The threats to that scenario are competition, not just from domestic peer OpenAI but also from Chinese AI labs, and the risk that regulation slows development of AI itself or of its supporting infrastructure.

Anthropic is not a total price-taker here. The deal is so large that many investors will want to own the company because of its future influence on the trajectory of the overall market.

But there should be no shame in having an IPO valuation closer to $1 trillion than the $2 trillion originally envisaged. Anthropic should want its shares to pop on debut, potentially fuelling upward momentum that would assist future stock sales.

It is only selling a small slice of itself, and haggling for the best IPO price would put the post-float performance at risk for a relatively small financial bonus. Sometimes IPO candidates just have to accept the going rate and get on with it. ©BLOOMBERG

MY VIEW | STATISTICALLY SPEAKING

Why the private school bill is key in measuring poverty

T.C.A. ANANT

is a visiting professor at the Institute for Studies of Industrial Development & Institute for Human Development, and former chief statistician of India.

In this paper, on 16 May 2024, I argued that the poverty line, framed in the 1970s around a calorie norm, says little about whether a household can afford a decent standard of living. The Tendulkar and Rangarajan committees revised the older norms but made no normative assessment of non-food needs. I discussed developing new normative criteria for both education and health expenditures as pathways out of poverty.

I suggested that private coaching creates an 'education poverty' that an average calorie-based line cannot see. Recent National Sample Survey (NSS) data offer insight into this problem and show how the growing role of private providers affects the poorest segments. The evidence comes from the Periodic Labour Force Survey 2025, Annual Survey of Unincorporated Sector Enterprises 2025, the NSS 80th round modular survey on education, the 2010-11 Unincorporated Non-Agricultural Enterprises Survey and the 2011-12 Employment-Unemployment Survey. Some highlights are worth noting.

First, the non-public sector seems to have grown. National accounts don't publish education by institutional sector; we can estimate a lower bound by subtracting public-sector 'other services' from education value added. Using the 2011-12 series, at least 10% of education value added came from outside the public sector in 2011-12, 19% in 2015-16 and 33% in 2023-24. Employment shows a smaller shift. Education employs 3.3% of India's workers; the for-profit share rose from 32.8% to 35.5% between 2011-12 and 2025, government share fell from 54.6% to 48.6%, and trusts and other non-profits rose from 8.8% to 15.3%. Most for-profit providers are small: 84% of their workers are in proprietary enterprises and 12% in companies.

Second, the household bill. In the NSS survey on education conducted in April-June 2025, students in private unaided schools were a third of the total but accounted for 73% of household school spending, about ₹2.2 trillion of ₹3.1 trillion. Households spent a further ₹58,000 crore on private coaching, which 27% of school students take. 'Private unaided' is not synonymous with for-profit, since trusts run many such schools, but it is the closest category the survey offers.

Third, coaching is a reflection of public failure. Government school students, 56% of the total, are more likely to take coaching than students in private unaided schools (27% against 24%), though less likely than those in aided schools (35%). Those who take it pay ₹6,900 a year, compared with ₹11,700 for students from private unaided schools (part of the gap reflects the lower incomes of government-school families), but that is nearly twice what their families spend on the school itself; in private unaided schools, it is about a third. Government school students account for 43% of all coaching spending. Coaching is most common in Tripura (79% of students), West Bengal (75%), Odisha (57%) and Bihar (53%). It is a private levy on public (non) provision. Tuition and coaching establishments in unincorporated enterprise surveys rose from 4.9 lakh in 2010-11 to 8.6 lakh in 2022-23, and to about 15 lakh in 2025 (partly a design change). Yet these units, 94% of them with a single worker, produce output equal to only about a third of what households report paying for school coaching. The money appears to flow mainly to companies, institutes and teachers outside the coverage of the enterprise surveys. At present, the available data account for the tail, not the head.

Fourth, the burden falls on exactly the households a poverty line is meant to protect. Households with a school-going child spend 13.9% of their consumption on school, coaching and hostels, 11% in rural and 18% in urban areas, with coaching alone at 2.2%. In the poorest quintile of these households, the outlay is 12.7% of consumption. The poorest households have more children: about 1.6 to 1.8 children aged 0 to 14 per household in the poorest quintile, against 0.4 in the richest. The expenditure shares may understate the pressure, because poorer families spend far fewer rupees per student: ₹646 a month in the poorest fifth of these households, ₹1,162 in the middle fifth and ₹2,544 in the richest. If the poorest fifth spent per student what the middle fifth spends, education would take about 23% of their consumption. The problem is we have no benchmark for what level of education spending is adequate.

Fifth, the for-profit providers pay their workers poorly. Regular wage workers in for-profit education earn a median ₹12,000 a month, compared with ₹38,500 in government education; for graduates, the figures are ₹15,000 and ₹46,000, and 68% of regular workers in for-profit education have no written contract. Half of coaching workers are under 30, 63% are women, and 70% are graduates; self-employed tutors report a median ₹5,500 a month.

A normative poverty standard would define a minimum education bundle, either a school good enough that tuition is unnecessary or a system of tuition that is affordable, and test whether a household can afford it alongside its food and health requirements. Comparisons are odious, but it's worth noting that in 2021, China undertook reforms to reduce the burden of private for-profit tuition in school subjects on households. These may be worth examining. As we aim for Viksit Bharat, recognizing out-of-pocket school expenditure should be a requirement of a revised poverty standard.

QUICK READ

Private coaching creates an 'education poverty' that a calorie-based poverty line can't see. Official surveys show how this affects the poorest segments of society the most.

India needs a normative poverty standard that defines a minimum education bundle of schooling and tuition that is affordable. China's reforms to cut private tuition can help.

A new Bordeaux to be served chilled and enjoyed young

There's a new red in town, Bordeaux Claret, a fruity, relatively light-bodied wine that you can pop open, straight from the fridge, and sip

Ruma Singh

I recently joined a webinar on 'New Expressions of Bordeaux' and listened to experts introduce new initiatives. One caught my attention: a new category of Bordeaux red wine. Named Bordeaux Claret, this red, fruity, relatively light-bodied wine, low in tannin, was intended to be served chilled and enjoyed young.

It is no secret that wine sales worldwide are under pressure, with falling sales attributed to everything from international conflict to economic pressures, and most especially, to younger generations turning away from alcohol. Was the world-famous wine region, synonymous with historic chateaux and cellar-worthy wines, attempting a marketing coup by introducing Bordeaux Claret? This, as per official sources, was a wine you could pop open after a day at work: at 10-12 degrees Celsius straight from the fridge, and sip immediately. A remarkable pivot in style.

Stéphanie Sinoquet, managing director of the Bordeaux and Bordeaux Supérieur Growers' Union, the body that initiated the Bordeaux Claret designation within the Bordeaux PDO (Protected Designation of Origin) specifications, says this is not a marketing campaign. Bordeaux Claret was being given a defined and legally regulated status within Bordeaux PDO. From the 2025 vintage onwards, wines using the designation must comply with specific technical requirements.

"Already, around 40 winemakers in Bordeaux have committed to producing Bordeaux Claret from the 2025 vintage, representing more than 16,000 hectolitres, with an estimated two million bottles expected to reach the market within the following two years," she said.

ISTOCKPHOTO

The Bordeaux region; and (above) the Bordeaux Claret.

A HINT OF HISTORY

The rapidly warming world has welcomed light, chilled wines. "Claret is a regulated 'mention traditionnelle' (an official, government-protected phrase used on product labels), not a new appellation or product," she says. In fact, the very word 'Claret' has heritage value in the Bordeaux region, going back centuries. The initiative by the Bordeaux and Bordeaux Supérieur Wine Growers' Union merely tapped into this long-standing narrative, undertook the consultation process and worked on the specs. "The objective is therefore both historical and forward-looking: to revive the original meaning of Claret—a lighter, clearer style of red wine, to be produced using modern winemaking techniques and precise technical specifications."

Drinkers interested in seeking it out on retail shelves must look for 'Bordeaux' as the primary appellation with 'Claret' written alongside, on the bottle.

Today, 'claret' is widely used by the British to refer to Bordeaux red wines. But 'Bordeaux Claret' is far from a British term adopted by the Bordelais, Sinoquet explained. When Eleanor of Aquitaine married Henry Plantagenet (later Henry II of England) in 1152, the British love affair with claret (spelled with a small C) from Bordeaux began. At the time, the wine was a pale, clear, light-bodied red, a vinum clarum. From the 18th century onwards, the word gradually became associated with all Bordeaux reds, now being made in a richer, fuller and more structured style—a wine the British continued to call "claret." So, far from adopting a British marketing term, this was taking a page out of history—the revival of the original pale light-bodied Bordeaux claret in a new era, she said.

She dismantled another widespread belief: that Bordeaux wine is always structured, full-bodied and complex. This idea is not wrong, just limited, she said. "That description may apply to some of Bordeaux's most famous PDOs like Medoc and particularly certain classified growths and prestigious estates, but it does not represent the full diversity of Bordeaux wines. Bordeaux produces red, white and rosé wines, and within Bordeaux reds themselves there is a wide range of styles: from fresh, fruit-driven and approachable wines to more intense, structured and age-worthy expressions. So, Bordeaux already has the grape varieties, the know-how and the diversity of styles to produce different expressions. Bordeaux Claret is not asking producers to do something contrary to the identity of Bordeaux; it is simply defining more precisely one particular style within that diversity," she emphasized.

> Bordeaux, the world's most famous wine region, has adapted its winemaking over centuries to changing tastes

A DIVERSE REGION

Sinoquet underlined the fact that Bordeaux has always been a diverse wine region capable of producing a wide range of styles. "In the 12th century, Bordeaux was famous for its lighter red wines. Later, styles evolved. Consumer tastes evolved. Winemaking evolved. Markets evolved. And Bordeaux evolved with them."

So, she countered, which moment in history should we choose as the "real" Bordeaux? The Bordeaux of the 12th century? The Bordeaux of the 18th century? The Bordeaux of the 20th century?

"The truth is that Bordeaux has always adapted, century after century, while remaining Bordeaux. That is precisely its strength. Bordeaux is not defined by one colour, one style, one level of tannin or one way of drinking wine. It is defined by an origin, a terroir, grape varieties, know-how and an extraordinary capacity for diversity."

The primary driver is clearly consumer relevance, in particular the need to reconnect with younger drinkers and the need to adapt to contemporary drinking occasions.

But the underlying consumer trends of today—lighter styles, freshness, flexibility and more informal drinking occasions—are not simply a passing fad. The marketing is certainly there—Bordeaux, like every other major wine region today, seeks new drinkers, new occasions and new relevance. But underneath the modern packaging and youthful marketing campaign is an old style of wine, now re-defined and reimagined for the contemporary drinker.

So, the question, then, is not whether Bordeaux has morphed into something else. It is whether wine drinkers are ready to accept this new, reimagined profile of Bordeaux.

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KNOW YOUR RED WINE

As per the official rulebook for Bordeaux, the grapes permitted to be used for Bordeaux reds include principal varieties, Cabernet Sauvignon, Cabernet Franc, Merlot, Malbec, Petit Verdot, Carmenère with up to 10% of secondary varieties, Arinarnoa, Castets, Marselan, and Touriga Nacional. Permitted sugar is up to 7g/l and minimum alcohol is 11%. It's a lighter-bodied, low tannin wine.

Bordeaux Claret (meaning 'light and clear') is the traditional name of the deeply-hued Bordeaux rosé that resembles a pale red. It has its own PDO and is made in a fruit-driven style and served chilled.

By Barkha Gupta.

For the weekend

Momo, ceramic tiles and picantes

A *Mint* guide to what's happening in and around the city

DELHI

MOVING BETWEEN FIXED AND FLOW

Till 30 November

This solo exhibition of ceramic tiles and drawings by Delhi-based visual artist Barkha Gupta was developed at Hampi Art Labs. Her work draws parallels between embroidery, sewing and stitching surfaces.

11am-6pm (Sundays closed). Exhibit 320, F-320, Lado Sarai.

MUMBAI

FLAVOURS OF TIBET

15 November

Savour the flavours of Tibet with a special menu by chef Doma Wang, celebrating the region's cuisine. Dishes include a variety of momo, Salmon Lephing, Chilli Butter Wings, Timbur Corn Ribs, Mushroom and Chives Noodles with Timbur, Khatsa Fried Rice and Men Tse Tse.

Noon to 4pm/7pm to 12.30am. House of Akina, Golden Palace, Linking Road, Bandra West.

Chicken Kothe Momos at Mumbai's House of Akina.

BENGALURU

BAR SHIFT

19 November

The third edition of this cocktail-focused festival will feature conversations on the art of a good pour, alongside a curated cocktail menu. Highlights include the tequila-led Garden Heat and the Classic Piccante.

8.30pm. Olive Beach, Ashok Nagar.

A BENGALI WINTER, SERVED HOME

Till 20 November

Kolkata-based chef Polash Mandal brings the flavours of home to this food pop-up. The *bhuribhoj* begins with Aloor Chop, Topshe Fry and Lote Maach Bhaja. The main course features Katla Fulkopi Kaliya and Jhinge Posto, alongside the classic combination of Kosha Mangsho and Basanti Pulao. Nolen Gurer Payesh, Rosogolla and Mishti Doi round off the meal.

7-11pm. JW Kitchen, JW Marriott Hotel Bengaluru, KG Halli, Shanthala Nagar.

Fast & Furious tourists flock to Japan for a taste of *Tokyo Drift*

People from all over the world are coming for rare Toyota and Nissan models immortalized by the movie franchise

Bloomberg

As the sun sets over Tokyo, dozens of Japanese muscle cars erupt into life, their engines growling as they head for the city's neon-lit highways.

The vehicles belong to tour operators ferrying a new wave of tourists chasing the latest bucket-list Japanese attraction: the world of the *Fast & Furious* movie franchise. They flock to spots where enthusiasts show off their cars, often highly modified Toyota, Honda or Nissan models rarely seen abroad. Their owners speed them over elevated expressways or drift them, tires screeching, at public events for eager spectators.

Fuelled by social media and a weak yen that makes visits affordable and attractive, the fans who come to soak in the country's unique car culture are a subset of a broader global obsession with Japan—a boom that's making tourism a major part of the economy. The Japanese Domestic Market, or JDM, as the retro-racer movement is known, is on track to almost double to $6.1 billion by 2033, according to one estimate.

At the A Pit Autobacs store in Shinonome, a vast tract of reclaimed land in the middle of Tokyo Bay, local JDM enthusiasts and tourists congregate to shop for parts and accessories and admire the rare models parked outside. Spread across three floors, Autobacs is designed as a lifestyle hub for gearheads, featuring a tuning workshop, hundreds of shelves stocking anything from racing shoes to performance exhausts, and even an in-store Starbucks.

At the parking garage, Masahiko Seki is showing off his 1984 Toyota Soarer, which he bought some 25 years ago for just ¥50,000 ($316). Since then, Seki has spent around ¥7 million turning it into a gleaming white lowrider with a refurbished engine. He's grateful for the attention from the tourists, and even managed to get a rare part for his car from a JDM fan in Australia, who brought it over on a trip after they connected on Instagram.

From the Autobacs store, it's a straight shot to Daikoku, a highway rest stop in Yokohama known as the main pilgrimage site for JDM fans.

A still from *The Fast and the Furious: Tokyo Drift*.

Andrei Zaev from Novosibirsk joined a JDM tour in a souped-up Mitsubishi Motors Lancer. As he steps out at Daikoku, his eyes widen as he points out vehicles he's only seen in movies or computer games. There are several Nissan GT-Rs, Mazda RX-7s and a Nissan Fairlady Z33—one of the models featured in *Tokyo Drift*, the third *Fast & Furious* movie that's achieved cult status with JDM fans. "Going to Japan and not seeing this culture would be strange," Zaev says.

Dozens of tourists walk between a sea of cars parked below a concrete canopy of winding elevated expressways. They're snapping pictures, posing in front of hot-rods or chatting with owners. You can hear English, French, Spanish and Arabic.

Fabrizio Tettoni and Jacinda Owens from Australia were there with her teenage son, whose fascination with muscle cars made Daikoku a non-negotiable destination on their vacation to Japan. It was "the cherry on top," Tettoni says. "I've never seen his eyes light up like that."

JDM got its start in the 1960s, when Japan's economic growth sparked mass automobile ownership and a fascination with tuning. In the 1980s, street-racing clubs formed that became so infamous they sparked manga and anime. The scene gained recognition in the early 2000s through film and blockbuster video game franchises such as *Gran Turismo*.

These days, hundreds of JDM-related experiences are offered on platforms such as Airbnb, Klook and Trip.com. They range from around $40 for a group tour in a van to roughly $1,600 for a private drive in a Lamborghini Aventador.

One site, SoftBank Group Corp.-backed GetYourGuide, said the number of JDM tours on its platform has more than tripled in the past two years, making them one of the fastest-growing traveller experiences in Japan. And with the yen still trading near historic lows, travellers are willing to pay for unique experiences.

Spending by foreign visitors to Japan rose to a record ¥7.1 trillion in the first nine months of this year, even as arrivals slow due to a slump in tourism from China. But the hype has a cost.

Like the overtourism plaguing Mount Fuji and Kyoto, Daikoku's gatherings can get out of hand.

Lacking public transit, tourists have been known to climb over security perimeters. While the meetings at Daikoku themselves aren't illegal, the crowds often swell until authorities inevitably shut the place down because the space and surrounding roads get too congested. Just 20 minutes into Zaev's visit to Daikoku, wailing police cars arrive, blaring orders over loudspeakers to disperse and triggering a sudden, thunderous roar as dozens of engines fire up and file back onto the expressway.

Zaev takes it in stride. Seeing Daikoku, even if only for a short time, was "amazing, impressive, head-breaking and cool," he says. "It's all about cars—for me that's enough."

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